



Bicycle-Friendly Trains

Where Amtrak Stands on Bicycle Access—and What Comes Next



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Executive Summary

Bicycles and trains belong together. They share the same appeal—freedom, human scale, a slower pass through the landscape—and together they form one of the cleanest, most accessible ways to travel within and between American communities. Yet for the person standing on an Amtrak platform with a loaded touring bike or the recreational rider ready to use the train to facilitate a weekend bicycling getaway, the journey ahead may not be so simple. Whether the train portion of their journey is easy, expensive, or impossible depends on a patchwork of policies, equipment, and station-level decisions that vary line by line and stop by stop.

This report, prepared by the League of American Bicyclists on behalf of the Amtrak Bike Task Force, is the first systematic benchmark of how accessible by bike Amtrak's 46 lines actually are. Inspired by the European Cyclists' Federation's *Cyclists Love Trains* reports (2021 and 2025), we adapted the ECF framework for the American context while adjusting for the absence of national bikeshare integration, the central role of state Departments of Transportation (DOTs) in route economics, and the practical importance of station staffing for checked-bicycle service. Using criteria adjusted for a national train system very different from that of Europe, we scored every Amtrak line from 0-100, on an Excellent to Very Poor scale, across hardware, software, and station-access criteria.

What We Found

- **The top of the American chart is strong.** The *Cascades* (87) and *Gold Runner* (86) earned the only two scores in the Excellent band (80-100), while the *Hiawatha* (78), *Pacific Surfliner* (75), and *Wolverine* (74) led out the Good tier.
- **The middle of the chart is crowded.** Two-thirds (67%) of bike-service lines fall into the Moderate band (40-59), and the average Amtrak line with bike service(s) offered scores in the low 50s (52.0).
- **Offering both carry-on and trainside checked service is the single strongest correlate of high performance.** Lines that offer both average 76.8; lines offering only one average about 49—though this gap also reflects sustained state DOT investment in the dual-mode corridors.
- **The Airo trainset rollout will lift many lines.** Beginning in 2026, the new Airo fleet doubles bike capacity on many routes and retires the front-wheel-removal requirement. The *Vermont*, for example, is projected to move from Moderate (51) to Good (71) once Airo equipment enters service.
- **Seven lines currently offer no bicycle service at all and account for the entire Very Poor band.**

What It Will Take to Improve

An Amtrak that is accessible by more bicyclists is not Amtrak's project alone. Amtrak owns only 13% of stations, 9% of platforms, and 7% of parking facilities on its network, and 97% of its route-miles run on tracks owned by others.¹ The

most consequential improvements documented in this report—Anniston, Alabama's platform extension, the *Capitol Corridor's* bikeshare payment-integration pilot, the Cola Town Bike Collective's wayfinding signage in Columbia, South Carolina—were led by cities, regional rail commissions, universities, joint powers authorities, and small nonprofits, not by Amtrak.

The report's recommendations are organized accordingly:

- **For Amtrak:** publish a clear, at-a-glance list of which stations offer bike service; fix reservation-system inconsistencies; expand service at high-potential unstaffed stations such as Anniston, Alabama (**ATN**); White Sulphur Springs, West Virginia (**WSS**); and Greenville, South Carolina (**GRV**); and offer a bundled USA Rail + Bikes Pass that treats a bicycle as part of the trip rather than a \$20-per-segment surcharge.
- **For station and platform owners:** ensure safe approaches, secure bicycle parking, visible signage, and bikeshare integration where possible.
- **For communities, businesses, and advocates:** pursue Bicycle Friendly CommunitySM and Bicycle Friendly BusinessSM designation, advocate at the state level for reduced or eliminated bicycle carriage fees on state-supported routes, and build the last-mile infrastructure that makes the train a practical choice.

The benchmark established here is meant to be revisited. As the Airo fleet rolls out, as more states subsidize bicycle carriage, and as more communities follow the Anniston, Davis, and Columbia models, we expect the next edition of this report to record meaningfully higher scores across the network.

¹ Amtrak. (2024a). "Amtrak 2024 Host Railroad Report Card and FAQs" (pp. 1-6). <https://www.amtrak.com/content/dam/projects/dotcom/english/public/documents/corporate/HostRailroadReports/Amtrak-2024-Host-Railroad-Report-Card.pdf>

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Bicycle-Friendly Trains is the product of collaboration across a wide network of advocates, practitioners, and institutional partners, without whom this benchmark report would not have been possible.

The members of the Amtrak Bicycle Task Force and its partner organizations provided the foundation for this work, lending their expertise, perspective, and commitment to advancing bicycle access on intercity rail throughout the research and production process.

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At Amtrak, Mariah Morales, Senior Director of External & Regulatory Affairs, and Thomas Davidenko, Government Affairs Specialist, were instrumental in facilitating access to the data underlying this analysis, including the bicycle capacity figures on which every line's hardware score rests. We also thank Trevor Bache, who compiled and provided those capacity figures while supporting Amtrak's External & Regulatory Affairs team. Their responsiveness and support proved essential to the integrity of the benchmarking effort.

The report draws directly on the *Cyclists Love Trains* framework developed by the European Cyclists' Federation. We are grateful to Fabian Küster of ECF for his consultation in September 2025 and for providing a video walkthrough of the original framework's methodology for the 2026 National Bike Summit audience, which helped ground this American adaptation in the spirit of the original work.²

At the League of American Bicyclists, this report was researched, written, and prepared by Will Simpson, federal policy fellow, while the graphic design and communications staff shaped the report's visual presentation and public outreach. League staff contributed editorial review and direction throughout the production process. Special thanks are due to Caron Whitaker, whose guidance and hands-on assistance from the earliest stages of this project through its completion were indispensable.

Finally, the League thanks Noelle Battle of Bikepacking Roots and Regan Freeman of Palmetto Walk Bike for previewing the report's findings at a pre-publication League webinar, "Bikes on Amtrak: A New Roadmap from the Task Force," held June 2, 2026. Their willingness to bring the findings to a broader audience before publication reflected the collaborative spirit that defines the bicycle advocacy community.

Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

The author used Claude, an AI language model developed by Anthropic, to support portions of the data analysis in this report. AI assistance was limited to the interpretation of scoring results. All bicycle-inclusivity scores were determined manually by the author in accordance with the scoring methodology described herein; no scores were generated or modified using AI. The League of American Bicyclists retains full responsibility for the findings, recommendations, and conclusions presented in this report.

² A recording of Fabian Küster—ECF's Director of Advocacy and European Union Affairs—going through his slides can be found in the citation below:

Küster, F. (2026, March 25). *Cyclists Love Trains 2.0* Report—U.S. National Bike Summit. In *Enhancing Amtrak's Bicycle Accessibility: Insights from Europe* [Virtual]. National Bike Summit, Washington, D.C. <https://drive.google.com/file/d/1o71VQgQIAGLRMracV8Gi3JYKe4F6bAMl/view?usp=sharing>

Introduction

Rolling through the countryside, fields whirring by, without having to be behind the wheel of a car. These are the possibilities when you go by bike—or train. So it's not surprising how many people combine these two forms of travel. Trains and bikes can go together to create safe, enjoyable, and clean transportation options within and between communities.

For the League of American Bicyclists, making train travel with bikes easier is a vital part of building a Bicycle Friendly AmericaSM for Everyone. That is why the League joined the Amtrak Bike Task Force and agreed to host it in 2022, after a decade of leadership by the Adventure Cycling Association.

This report was inspired by the *Cyclists Love Trains* reports by the European Cyclists' Federation (ECF), which rated train lines across Europe in 2021 and 2025. After adjusting the criteria for the American context, we were able to rate each Amtrak line and identify best practices and recommendations for Amtrak to improve its systems for bicyclists.

One of our main takeaways, however, is understanding that improving train travel for bicyclists is not just up to Amtrak. It will take collaboration among local governments, train station owners, local businesses, and advocates to build a train network that is welcoming to people who bike.

We hope this report can serve as a roadmap for improving bike-inclusive train travel across the country.

"When the spirits are low, when the day appears dark, when work becomes monotonous, when hope hardly seems worth having, just mount a bicycle and go out for a spin down the road, without thought of anything but the ride you are taking."
-Sir Arthur Conan Doyle³

"At their best, trains are appealing because they retain a human scale. And in an age of disconnection—when we talk to one another by tweet and text—that human connection becomes more novel and more precious. Unlike a jetliner, it's not an abstraction of human living from 30,000 feet. Nor is it the back of another car with the same 20 chain storefronts sliding by like a cheaply animated cartoon. On a train, you look out the window at trees and rivers and people's backyards, slicing through people's lives at 79 mph."
-Bob Guccione, Jr.⁴

3 "The Adventure Cyclist." (2019, November 13). The Conan Doyle Estate. <https://conandoyleestate.com/news/adventure-cyclist-sherlock-holmes>

4 Guccione, Jr., B. (2026, March 30). "How Trainspotting Never Gets Old." *Insider Travel Report*. <https://www.insidertravelreport.com/insider-by-wonderlust-how-trainspotting-never-gets-old>



Background

The Amtrak Bike Task Force

Created over a decade ago and coordinated by the League since 2022, the Amtrak Bike Task Force (“Task Force”) is a nationwide coalition of stakeholders, including representatives from a range of bike-related organizations and members of Amtrak’s External and Regulatory Affairs team. Organizations involved in the Task Force range from national organizations—such as the Adventure Cycling Association, Bikepacking Roots, Rails to Trails Conservancy, and the East Coast Greenway Alliance—to statewide and local groups, including South Carolina’s Palmetto Walk Bike and Albuquerque, New Mexico’s BikeABQ (see [Appendix TT](#) for full list of Task Force member organizations).

Throughout this report, you will find details from each of these organizations on their interest in improving bike travel on trains.

The League of American Bicyclists

In 1880, the bicyclists of the day—then known as “wheelmen”—founded the League of American Wheelmen to advocate for better roads than the rutted dirt and gravel ones they faced every day. In an effort to improve riding conditions, more than 100,000 bicyclists from across the United States joined the League to advocate for paved roads.⁵

Today, the League of American Bicyclists’ mission is to build a Bicycle Friendly AmericaSM for everyone. Our Bicycle Friendly AmericaSM program sets criteria for what makes a community, business, or university worthy of recognition and then certifies those entities as Bicycle FriendlySM. You can find our list of Bicycle Friendly AmericaSM awardees [on our website](#).

However, creating a Bicycle Friendly AmericaSM for everyone is enhanced by the ability to travel not just by bike within your community but with your bike between places by train.

Amtrak

Officially the National Railroad Passenger Corporation, Amtrak is the national passenger railroad service of the United States, providing intercity rail travel across 46 states, the District of Columbia, and three Canadian provinces.⁶ Created by Congress in 1970,⁷ Amtrak operates over 300 trains daily, connecting more than 500 destinations over 21,400 miles of routes.⁸ It is a federally chartered, for-profit corporation where the U.S. government is the majority stockholder.⁹ While operated and managed as a for-profit corporation, Amtrak is accountable to its majority stockholder, the United States federal government, and Congress never seriously expected Amtrak to be profitable—instead directing it to provide modern, cost-efficient intercity rail passenger transportation throughout the country.^{10 11 12}

5 The League of American Bicyclists. (n.d.). “Equity and Our History.” <https://bikeleague.org/about/equity-and-history/>

6 Federal Railroad Administration. (2022, February 14). “Amtrak.” U.S. Department of Transportation. <https://railroads.dot.gov/passenger-rail/amtrak/amtrak>

7 Rail Passenger Service Act of 1970, Pub. L. No. 91-518, 84 Stat. 1327 (1970). <https://www.govinfo.gov/content/pkg/STATUTE-84/pdf/STATUTE-84-Pg1327.pdf>

8 Federal Register. (n.d.). “Agencies: National Railroad Passenger Corporation.” <https://www.federalregister.gov/agencies/national-railroad-passenger-corporation>

9 Amtrak. (2024b). “Company Profile for FY 2024” (pp. 1-9). <https://www.amtrak.com/content/dam/projects/dotcom/english/public/documents/corporate/nationalfactsheets/Amtrak-Company-Profile-FY2024-032425.pdf>

10 Amtrak. (n.d.-a). “Answers to Stakeholder Questions about Amtrak.” <https://www.amtrak.com/stakeholder-faqs>

11 Amtrak. (2025b). “White Paper: Amtrak’s Financial Performance” (pp. 1-6). <https://www.amtrak.com/content/dam/projects/dotcom/english/public/documents/corporate/amtrak-financial-performance-faqs-03052025.pdf>

12 Amtrak’s statutory mission and goals are codified at 49 U.S.C. § 24101(b), (c), <https://uscode.house.gov/view.xhtml?req=granuleid:USC-prelim-title49-section24101&num=0&edition=prelim>.

Amtrak divides its routes into three service lines, which group routes according to their funding source and service characteristics:

- **Northeast Corridor (NEC):** Northeast Regional and high-speed Acela service on the electrified, largely Amtrak-owned main line between Washington, D.C. and Boston.
- **State-Supported routes:** corridor routes up to 750 miles in length, generally operated over unelectrified “host” railroad tracks, for which sponsoring states work with Amtrak to determine the exact route, station stops, and service frequency, and for which those states provide operating support.
- **Long Distance routes:** routes at least 750 miles in length, generally operated over unelectrified “host” railroad tracks, for which the federal government provides operating support.

The State-Supported and Long Distance service lines together form Amtrak’s “National Network,” distinct from the NEC.¹³ This distinction matters for bicycle policy because decision-making varies across the three lines: on the NEC, Amtrak itself sets most of the terms; on State-Supported routes, sponsoring states have significant influence over service characteristics; and on Long Distance routes, Amtrak operates under federal support across host-railroad infrastructure.

While Amtrak is generally thought of as one entity, there are actually many actors influencing how each line accommodates bicycles. For instance, 97% of route-miles traveled by Amtrak trains are on tracks owned by other, “host” railroads.¹⁴ In many states, like North Carolina and Wisconsin, the state Department of Transportation owns the tracks on which Amtrak operates. In those cases, the state can determine the cost to carry a bike on board.¹⁵ When determining how to make those train lines more welcoming to bikes, engaging the state is necessary.

Another consideration is the stations and platforms. It is certainly easier to bring your bike onto the train with you if the platform and train are at the same height, and it is easier to do a bike-train or train-bike trip if there is bikeshare and quality bike parking at the station.

However, of the 500-plus stations served, Amtrak owns only 61 (13%) of the approximately 459 station structures. Additionally, as of 2021, the national rail operator has sole ownership of 45 (9%) of the 482 platforms; and only 33 (7%) of the 453 parking facilities.¹⁶ For such cases, this report includes recommendations for station, platform, and parking lot owners.

13 Amtrak. (n.d.-a). “Answers to Stakeholder Questions About Amtrak.” <https://www.amtrak.com/stakeholder-faqs>

14 Amtrak. (2024a). “Amtrak 2024 Host Railroad Report Card and FAQs” (pp. 1-6). <https://www.amtrak.com/content/dam/projects/dotcom/english/public/documents/corporate/HostRailroadReports/Amtrak-2024-Host-Railroad-Report-Card.pdf>

15 Whitaker, C. (2024, June 21). “Amtrak Agrees to Better Bicycle Access.” The League of American Bicyclists. <https://bikeleague.org/amtrak-agrees-to-better-bicycle-access/>

16 Amtrak. (2021). “Stations Appendices: Amtrak’s FY 2022-2027 Service and Asset Line Plans” (pp. 1-68). <https://www.amtrak.com/content/dam/projects/>



Amtrak Senior Director of External & Regulatory Affairs, Mariah Morales, in front of the redesigned bike racks on a new Airo trainset (Photo: Amtrak).



Standalone view of the dual-capacity bike rack on the Airo model trains. (Photo: Amtrak)

Airo Trains

In the 2021 Infrastructure Investment and Jobs Act, Congress appropriated funds for Amtrak to make major capital improvements.¹⁷ Amtrak used much of that funding to replace its aging train cars with 83 new **Airo** trainsets.¹⁸ This is the biggest revamp of their train cars since 1971,¹⁹ and had to respond to multiple legal requirements, including coming into compliance with the Americans with Disabilities Act,²⁰ and updating the trains with newer technology, stakeholder requests for larger seats, and other service improvements.²¹

It is also important to note that while Congress funded Amtrak to replace its existing stock of train cars, it did not fund Amtrak to increase overall capacity. This comes at a time of surging demand: in Fiscal Year 2025, Amtrak saw record ridership, with 34.5 million total customer trips—a 5.1% increase over the prior fiscal year. Amtrak customers also collectively logged 6.9 billion miles in FY25, an all-time high.²² This matters because it means bicycle storage on train cars will continue to compete with luggage storage.

Understanding that this was a once-in-a-lifetime investment, the Amtrak Bike Task Force advocated for the new equipment to include more and easier-to-use bike storage on trains. Amtrak agreed with the Task Force and designed the new cars to include one bike rack with space for two bikes per train car, which in many cases will double the bike capacity (see *left*). In addition, the new trains will no longer require bicyclists to remove their front wheels,²³ and the revised front-wheel rack hook will now hold bikes with wider tires (up to 3 inches), allowing for the storage of mountain and gravel bikes.

The Airo fleet began debuting in 2026 and will be rolled out on routes throughout the country, including the following services: *Cascades*, *Northeast Regional*, *Virginia Services*, *Carolinian*, *Keystone Service*, *Palmetto*, *Pennsylvanian*, *Vermont*, *Downeaster*, *Adirondack*, *Empire Service*, *Ethan Allen Express*, *Maple Leaf*, and *New Haven (CT) / Springfield (MA) service*.²⁴

[dotcom/english/public/documents/corporate/businessplanning/Amtrak-Stations-ALP-Appendix-FY22-27.pdf](https://www.amtrak.com/english/public/documents/corporate/businessplanning/Amtrak-Stations-ALP-Appendix-FY22-27.pdf)

17 Infrastructure Investment and Jobs Act, Pub. L. No. 117-58, 135 Stat. 429 (2021). [https://www.congress.gov/bill/117th-congress/house-bill/3684/text](https://www.congress.gov/bills/117/congress/house-bill/3684/text)

18 Amtrak. (2026). "Amtrak Airo Fleet." *Amtrak Media*. <https://media.amtrak.com/airo-fleet/>

19 Bardolf, D. (2026, February 14). "Amtrak Adding Over 80 New Trains in Massive Overhaul of Fleet; Travelers React." *Fox News*. <https://www.foxnews.com/travel/amtrak-adding-over-80-new-trains-massive-overhaul-fleet-travelers-react.amp>

20 Decker, C. (2013). "All Aboard (Except People With Disabilities): Amtrak's 23 Years of ADA Compliance Failure" (pp. 1-52). *National Disability Rights Network*. https://www.ndrn.org/images/Documents/Media/Publications/NDRN_Amtrak_Report.pdf

21 Watson, R. (2026, February 10). "Amtrak Offers First Look at Airo Equipment." *Trains Magazine*. <https://www.trains.com/pro/passenger/amtrak-offers-first-look-at-airo-equipment/>

22 Amtrak. (2025a). "Pay for Performance Rewards: Improve Performance, Reduce Costs, Retain Talent" (pp. 1-14). <https://www.amtrak.com/content/dam/projects/dotcom/english/public/documents/corporate/FY2025-Performance-Incentive-Program-122625.pdf>

23 Front wheel-removal is required on legacy rolling stock on the *Downeaster* and *Vermont* services today.

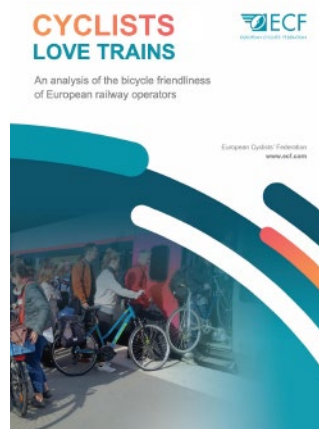
24 Amtrak. (2026). "Amtrak Airo Fleet." *Amtrak Media*. <https://media.amtrak.com/airo-fleet/>

Defining What Makes Trains Good for Bikes

The following research was inspired by two European Cyclists' Federation reports—the 2021²⁵ and 2025²⁶ editions of *Cyclists Love Trains*, which analyzed and scored the ease of traveling with a bike on 67 European long-distance rail carriers.

To produce a similar report on Amtrak, we needed to understand the many differences between train travel in the U.S. and European Union. Under Article 6(4) of Regulation (EU) 2021/782 on Rail Passengers' Rights and Obligations, which took effect on June 7, 2025, rail passengers are entitled to take a full-sized bicycle on board the train. The regulation also imposes a statutory minimum of four bicycle spaces per train composition on new and renovated rolling stock.²⁷

No such federal protections exist in the United States. Amtrak is not legally required to provide bicycle storage, nor are there U.S. rail passenger protections which would secure the right for passengers to bring a bike on board. Amtrak's bike access is a matter of internal policy and response to advocacy. In fact, other train systems in the U.S.—such as Brightline in Florida—expressly prohibit bikes in their terms of service.²⁸



25 Carnegie, C., Küster, F., & Lancaster, E. (2021). "Cyclists Love Trains: An Analysis of the Bicycle Friendliness of European Railway Operators" (pp. 1-126). European Cyclists' Federation. https://www.ecf.com/media/resources/2021/Cyclists_love_trains_report-2.pdf

26 Rozenburg, J., & Küster, F. (2025). "Cyclists Love Trains: An Analysis of the Bicycle Friendliness of European Railway Operators" (pp. 1-160). European Cyclists' Federation. <https://ecf.com/media/ecf%20at%20velo-city/CLT/Cyclists%20Love%20Trains%202025%20Report.pdf>

27 European Parliament & Council of the European Union. (2021). Regulation (EU) 2021/782 of the European Parliament and of the Council of 29 April 2021 on Rail Passengers' Rights and Obligations. Official Journal of the European Union, L 172, 1-52. <https://eur-lex.europa.eu/legal-content/EN/TXT/HTML/?uri=CELEX:32021R0782>

28 Brightline. (2026, April 27). "Terms of Service." <https://www.qobrightline.com/terms-of-service>

Methodology: US Criteria

This analysis evaluates Amtrak's bike-inclusiveness using a scoring framework adapted from the 2025 edition of the European Cyclists' Federation's *Cyclists Love Trains* report (see [Appendix A](#)). The adapted framework retains the ECF's two-category structure—hardware and software—but modifies the weighting and individual indicators to better reflect the American rail context (see [Appendix C](#) for detail on indicators excluded from the adapted framework and the redistribution of their points).

The full adapted criteria are detailed in [Appendix B](#). In brief, the framework scores each Amtrak line across the following indicators:

Hardware (50 points)

- **Bicycle Spaces* (50 points):** The average number of spaces available for unfolded bicycles on the train line.

Software (40 points)

- **Bicycle Ticket Cost (10 points):** The cost of purchasing a bicycle ticket. Across the Amtrak system, bicycle fees are \$0, \$5, \$10, or \$20, depending on the route and the degree of state subsidy. (See [Appendix G](#)).
- **Reservation Requirement (up to 10 points):** Whether an advance reservation is required to bring a bicycle onboard. Unlike the other software indicators, this criterion does not have a single “best practice”—requiring reservations benefits travelers planning ahead, while not requiring them benefits spontaneous travelers—so both configurations earn points, with a modest preference for the reservation-required model. However, for maximum points, a line would need to adopt a hybrid ticketing model in which some bicycle spaces required advance reservations and others did not. (See [Appendix M](#)).
- **Booking Channels (10 points):** The number of channels through which a bicycle ticket can be purchased or a reservation made. (See [Appendix S](#)).
- **Website/App Functionality (10 points):** The user-friendliness and functionality of Amtrak's website and mobile app for bicycle-related services. (See [Appendix L](#)).

Station Access (10 points)

- **Station Staffing (10 points):** The proportion of stations along the line that are staffed, calculated from Amtrak's published schedules. Because trainside checked bicycle service has historically required staffed stations to handle the bicycle, staffing levels meaningfully shape whether a line's bike services are accessible at the stations a traveler actually wants to use. (See [Appendix O](#) for the scoring rubric and [Appendices P](#) and [Q](#) for the calculation methodology).

Bike Storage (Variable)

- **Carry-On And Trainside Checked Service:** The framework also measures two types of bike storage: carry-on and trainside checked service. Neither carriage type earns more base points than the other—a line offering only carry-on can score just as high as a line offering only trainside checked service. Lines that offer both receive a +2 bonus (see [Appendix E](#)), reflecting the additional flexibility this gives passengers traveling with bicycles. Points were not awarded for the ability of stations to carry bikes that have been boxed, as this requires disassembly and is not equivalent to roll-on or trainside service. A fuller discussion of this treatment appears in the “Note on Scoring” on page 12.

**Bicycle capacity figures for all Amtrak lines were provided directly to the author by an Amtrak representative via email on September 24, 2025 (through an attached Excel workbook). See [Appendix J](#) for the scoring rubric applied to these figures.*

A Note on Total Points

- Indicator point values across the three categories sum to 100 possible points (50 Hardware + 40 Software + 10 Station Access), before the + 10 bonus/minus adjustments described below. The ECF framework allocates its 100 points between just two categories—60 to Hardware and 40 to Software—whereas we carved out Station Access as a distinct third category worth 10 points. In the American context, trainside checked bicycle service has historically depended on staffed stations to handle the bicycle, meaning a line's on-paper bike policy can diverge sharply from what a traveler will actually encounter at the stations along their route. Giving Station Access its own category surfaces that distinction rather than burying it inside Software.

Bonus/Minus Points (Max. +10/-10 points)

Additional points are awarded or deducted based on services or restrictions related to on-board bicycle carriage, such as whether the line accepts non-standard bicycles or requires wheel-removal for storage. The full set of adapted bonus and minus indicators is listed in [Appendix E](#).

A Note on Booking Channel Scoring

All Amtrak lines with bicycle service(s) offered received 10 points for having five or more booking channels available to purchase a bicycle ticket or make a reservation. Bicycle reservations or tickets can be made or purchased via:

1. The Amtrak mobile application;
2. The Amtrak website;
3. Calling Amtrak's official, toll-free customer service phone number at 1-800-USA-RAIL (1-800-872-7245);
4. Visiting a staffed ticket counter at an Amtrak station; or
5. Using a self-service kiosk (at certain Amtrak stations*).

*In October 2021, Amtrak announced the introduction of 200 new, state-of-the-art self-service kiosks in more than 150 stations across the country, which—among the “Add-Ons”—allow for bicycle ticket purchases or bike reservations to be made.²⁹

²⁹ Abrams, J. (2021, October 29). “Amtrak Debuts New Ticket Kiosks With National Rollout.” *Amtrak Media*. <https://media.amtrak.com/2021/10/amtrak-debuts-new-ticket-kiosks-with-national-rollout/>

Bicycle Services Offered

Across the Amtrak network, bicycles are accommodated in one of two ways: **carry-on service**, in which passengers bring their bicycle directly aboard the train and secure it on an in-car rack, and **trainside checked service**, in which passengers hand their bicycle to a station or train crew member for storage in a dedicated baggage car. A central concern raised by Amtrak Bike Task Force member organizations is that service is often inconsistent along a single route—a station mid-line may offer carry-on, trainside checked, or neither, even when adjacent stations do.³⁰

Carry-On Service

Carry-on service allows passengers to roll their bicycle directly from the platform into the train car and secure it on an interior rack for the duration of the trip. Because the passenger retains custody of the bike throughout, carry-on service does not depend on station staffing and can be offered at unstaffed stops. Below, a passenger boards a carry-on car on a long-distance route and then secures his bike to the in-car rack on the *Capitol Limited*.³¹

Trainside Checked Service

Trainside checked service, by contrast, requires the passenger to hand the bicycle to a conductor or baggage handler at the platform, who then stows it in a dedicated baggage car for the trip. This model can accommodate higher bicycle volumes per train but depends on the presence of staff at both the boarding and disembarking stations—a constraint examined in the next sub-section. The photos below, taken aboard the former *Hiawatha* luggage cars, illustrate both the trackside handoff and the in-car storage configuration.³²

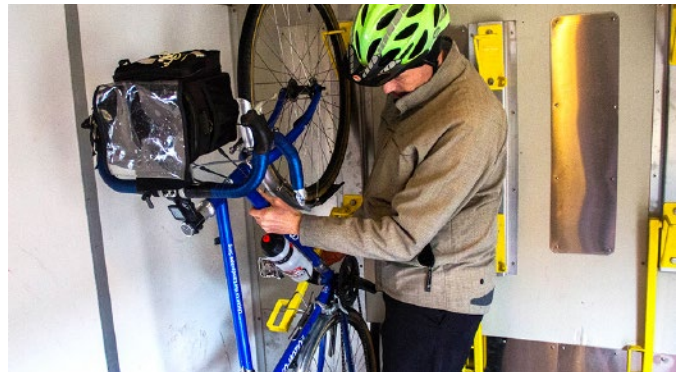
30 Certain Amtrak lines—including the *Cascades*, *Gold Runner*, and *Pacific Surfliner*—do offer both types of service; however, overall, trainside checked service is only available at select stations.

31 “How to Plan Your Bike Trip Using Amtrak.” (2019, May 17). Adventure Cycling Association. <https://www.adventurecycling.org/blog/amtrak-bike-service-what-is-it-where-to-find-it/>

32 *Streetsblog Chicago*. (2023, August 5). “Unfortunately, Amtrak Has Cut Bicycle Capacity on *Hiawatha* Service. But Bike-Friendly Venture Cars Are Coming.” <https://chi.streetsblog.org/2023/08/05/annoyingly-amtrak-has-cut-bicycle-capacity-on-hiawatha-service-but-bike-friendly-venture-cars-are-coming>



Jeff Miller loads his bike onto the appropriate Amtrak carry-on car.
(Photo: Saara Snow)



Jeff loads his bike on the carry-on racks provided by the *Capitol Limited* route.
(Photo: Saara Snow)



Handing a bike to a conductor on one of the old *Hiawatha* luggage cars in 2016.
(Photo: John Greenfield)



Bike racks in one of the old *Hiawatha* luggage cars in 2016. (Photo: John Greenfield)

A Note on Scoring

The scoring framework treats carry-on and trainside checked service as equivalent: neither carriage type earns more base points than the other, and a line offering only carry-on can score just as high as a line offering only trainside checked service.

What the framework does reward, through a +2 bonus, is the availability of *both* options on the same line. This bonus reflects the additional flexibility offered to passengers—for example, a traveler with a heavy touring rig may prefer to hand it off as checked baggage, while a traveler on a short trip may prefer to keep their bike with them—and is consistent with the European Cyclists' Federation's treatment of multi-modal flexibility in the 2025 *Cyclists Love Trains* report.

Station Staffing

Whether trainside checked service can actually be used along a route depends heavily on which stations on that route are staffed. While many Amtrak stations—particularly those in larger cities—have personnel who can check a bike or luggage, a significant number are either unstaffed or staffed only for limited hours. Traditionally, a passenger could not check a bike or piece of luggage at an unstaffed station, although Amtrak has made exceptions at some stops with consistently high bike traffic.

The *Cardinal* line in West Virginia illustrates how uneven this can be in practice. In the Mountain State, the unstaffed Prince station (**PRC**) recently began offering bicycle service while the nearby unstaffed White Sulphur Springs station (**WSS**) still does not. Amtrak does not currently publish route-level details on bicycle carriage, and its website does not include maps showing which individual stations allow bikes on trains, whether as carry-on or as checked baggage—leaving passengers to piece this information together themselves.

To capture this dimension in the scoring, the proportion of staffed to unstaffed stations on each line was calculated using Amtrak’s published train schedules for the week of March 9, 2026 (see [Appendix O](#) for the scoring breakdowns).³³ Because different services along the same route can have varying destinations depending on the day of the week, preference was given to the schedule with the most stops, so that each line was evaluated on the most complete picture available.

Two slightly different methods were used for domestic and international lines. For domestic services, every station along the line was counted; an example of this calculation for the *Hiawatha* line can be found in [Appendix P](#). For international routes, only the U.S. stations were measured in determining the staffing score; [Appendix Q](#) provides an illustration using the *Maple Leaf* train.

³³ After consultation with members of Amtrak’s External & Regulatory Affairs team, station staffing was chosen to be used as an imperfect but the best available proxy for station-level bicycle service.

Results

With the scoring framework established and the service types—carry-on, trainside checked, or a combination of the two—defined, we can now turn to how the 46 Amtrak lines actually perform against these criteria. The results that follow apply the indicators described above (bicycle spaces, ticket cost, reservation requirements, booking channels, website functionality, and station staffing) along with the bonus/minus adjustments to produce a single 0-100 score for each line, sorted into five performance bins ranging from Excellent (80-100) to Very Poor (0-19).

The table below presents the 39 lines that currently offer some form of on-board bicycle service. Lines without any bike service are excluded here to keep the focus on the comparative performance of routes where bicycle travel is actually possible; their scores are reported separately in the descriptive statistics section that follows and in full in [Appendix U](#).

An interactive version of the table is available [here](#), allowing readers to sort and filter by service type, scoring bin, or score. A static version appears on the following page.

A Note on Booking Channels

All Amtrak lines with bicycle service(s) offered received 10 points for having five or more booking channels available for purchasing a bicycle ticket, while Amtrak lines without any bike service offered received 0 points by default.

The booking channels indicator uses a straightforward linear scale rather than the European Cyclists' Federation's original criteria, which awarded 5 points to operators offering free onboard carriage without a reservation requirement ([Appendix H](#)). That accommodation was excluded here because the Task Force framework includes a dedicated Reservation Requirement indicator ([Appendix M](#)) that already evaluates whether reservations are needed and rewards hybrid systems accordingly. Retaining the ECF's 5-point tier would risk scoring the same policy dimension twice, artificially inflating scores for operators that happen to allow carry-on bicycle access. The simplified scale instead keeps this indicator focused exclusively on the number of available booking channels.

Bicycle Accessibility Score of Amtrak Lines with Bike Service(s) Offered

For Amtrak lines with bike service(s) offered, the following is a 0-100 measure—including +10 max./-10 min. bonus/minus points—of the accessibility of bringing one's bicycle onboard, based on adapted criteria from European Cyclists' Federation (*Cyclists Love Trains*) reports. Notes: * = Available at select stations; † = See "A Note on the *Capitol Corridor*" ([Appendix UU](#)); ‡ = Final Score reflects the average across this line's differently priced bike-ticket segments; see [Appendix U](#) for the per-segment breakdown.

Amtrak Line	Bicycle Service(s)	Final Score	Scoring Bin
<i>Blue Water</i>	Carry-On	72	Good
<i>California Zephyr</i>	Train-Side Checked*	50	Moderate
<i>Capitol Corridor</i> †	Carry-On	46	Moderate
<i>Cardinal</i>	Train-Side Checked*	51	Moderate
<i>Carolinian</i> ‡	Carry-On	49	Moderate
<i>Cascades</i>	Carry-On & Train-Side Checked*	87	Excellent
<i>Carl Sandburg</i>	Carry-On	42	Moderate
<i>City of New Orleans</i>	Train-Side Checked*	31	Poor
<i>Coast Starlight</i> ‡	Train-Side Checked*	59	Moderate
<i>Crescent</i>	Train-Side Checked*	52	Moderate
<i>Downeaster</i>	Carry-On	69	Good
<i>Empire Builder</i>	Train-Side Checked*	49	Moderate
<i>Empire Service</i>	Carry-On	43	Moderate
<i>Ethan Allen Express</i>	Carry-On	41	Moderate
<i>Floridian (previously Silver Star; Capitol Limited)</i>	Train-Side Checked*	33	Poor
<i>Gold Runner (previously San Joaquins)</i>	Carry-On & Train-Side Checked*	86	Excellent
<i>Hartford Line</i>	Carry-On	27	Poor
<i>Hiawatha</i>	Carry-On	78	Good
<i>Illini</i>	Carry-On	42	Moderate
<i>Illinois Zephyr</i>	Carry-On	42	Moderate
<i>Keystone Service</i>	Carry-On	31	Poor
<i>Lake Shore Limited</i>	Train-Side Checked*	52	Moderate
<i>Lincoln Service</i>	Carry-On	44	Moderate
<i>Maple Leaf</i>	Carry-On	43	Moderate
<i>Missouri River Runner</i>	Carry-On	41	Moderate
<i>Northeast Regional</i>	Carry-On	45	Moderate
<i>Pacific Surfliner</i>	Carry-On & Train-Side Checked*	75	Good
<i>Palmetto</i>	Train-Side Checked*	55	Moderate
<i>Pennsylvanian</i>	Train-Side Checked*	52	Moderate
<i>Pere Marquette</i>	Train-Side Checked*	73	Good
<i>Piedmont</i>	Carry-On & Train-Side Checked*	59	Moderate
<i>Saluki</i>	Carry-On	41	Moderate
<i>Silver Meteor</i>	Train-Side Checked*	54	Moderate
<i>Southwest Chief</i>	Train-Side Checked*	51	Moderate
<i>Sunset Limited</i>	Train-Side Checked*	52	Moderate
<i>Texas Eagle</i>	Train-Side Checked*	31	Poor
<i>Valley Flyer</i>	Carry-On	51	Moderate
<i>Vermont</i>	Carry-On	51	Moderate
<i>Wolverine</i>	Carry-On	74	Good

Data Summary

This section reports descriptive statistics for the scores of the 39 Amtrak lines that offer some form of on-board bicycle service (carry-on only, trainside checked only, or both). Lines without any bike service are excluded from the primary analysis but are summarized briefly at the end of this section for context; the full scoring breakdown across all 46 lines is provided in [Appendix U](#).³⁴

Overall Score Distribution

Across the 39 bike-service lines, the mean score is 51.95 and the median is 51, with both values falling near the center of the Moderate band (40–59) (see [Appendix LL](#)). The mode is 51, indicating that more lines cluster at the exact midpoint of the Moderate range than at any other single value. **Most Amtrak lines with bike service currently sit in the Moderate band, and the strong performance of the top-scoring routes points to real opportunities for the rest of the network to build on.**

Performance by Score Range

26 of the 39 lines (66.7%) fall into the Moderate band, while only two lines (5.1%) achieve an Excellent score and six lines (15.4%) qualify as Good. Five lines (12.8%) score in the Poor band, and notably **no line with bike service scores Very Poor**—offering any bicycle accommodation appears to lift a line above the 20-point floor, even when the program is still developing. The Excellent tier is led by *Cascades* (87) and *Gold Runner* (86), while *Hiawatha* (78), *Pacific Surfliner* (75), and *Wolverine* (74) round out the top five. The lines currently in the Poor tier—the *Hartford Line* (27), *City of New Orleans* (31), *Keystone Service* (31), *Texas Eagle* (31), and *Floridian* (33)—represent the network's clearest near-term opportunities for improvement.

Variation by Service Type

Disaggregating by the type of bicycle accommodation offered reveals the most actionable finding in the dataset. The 20 lines offering **carry-on service only** average **48.60**, and the 15 lines offering **trainside checked service** only average **49.67**—a difference of about one point. The four lines offering **both carry-on and trainside checked service**, however, average **76.75**—more than 27 points higher than either single-mode group, and well into the Good band. Median values follow the same pattern (43.5 and 52 for the single-mode groups; 80.5 for the dual-mode group). Three of the four dual-mode lines (*Cascades*, *Gold Runner*, and *Pacific Surfliner*) appear among the top six highest-scoring lines network-wide; the fourth, *Piedmont*, scores 59, at the top of the Moderate band. **Offering both service modes is the single strongest correlate of high bicycle-inclusiveness in this scoring framework.**

Two caveats are worth noting. First, a small portion of this gap (two points) reflects the +2 bonus that dual-mode lines receive by definition under the scoring framework (for a full breakdown of bonus/minus points by line, see [Appendix DD](#)). Second, and more substantively, the four dual-mode lines are concentrated among well-resourced state-supported corridors—*Cascades*, *Gold Runner*, *Pacific Surfliner*, and *Piedmont* all benefit from sustained state DOT investment and advocacy partnerships that tend to lift performance across multiple indicators simultaneously, not just service-mode availability. The dual-mode finding is therefore best read as a strong signal of what bike-inclusive corridors look like in practice, rather than as evidence that adding a second carriage type alone would close the 23-point gap.

³⁴ An interactive map of all 46 Amtrak routes is available [here](#). Each line (shown in blue) can be clicked to reveal its bicycle-inclusivity score alongside the full scoring breakdown—bicycle service offered, bike spaces per train set, ticket cost, reservation requirement, share of stations staffed, and any bonus/minus points. The map also plots every Amtrak station (in red) and overlays long-distance bike routes from Task Force member organizations—Bikepacking Roots (teal), Adventure Cycling Association (orange), and the East Coast Greenway Alliance (green)—along with the U.S. Bicycle Route System (USBRS, purple).

Context: Comparison with the Full Network

When the seven lines without any bike service are added to the analysis, the network-wide mean drops to **44.87**. The no-service group is tightly clustered at the bottom of the scale—a mean of 5.71 points and a maximum of just 10 (*Acela* and *Auto Train*)—and accounts for all seven lines in the Very Poor band (*Acela*, *Adirondack*, *Auto Train*, *Berkshire Flyer*, *Borealis*, *Heartland Flyer*, and *Mardi Gras*). The 46.18-point mean gap (see [Appendix KK](#)) between the with-service and without-service groups underscores that the presence of any bicycle accommodation is itself the most important determinant of a line's score; the type and quality of that accommodation then explains most of the remaining variation among lines that do offer service.

Disaggregating the full network by service type makes both halves of that pattern visible at once: the no-service lines average 5.71 (range 2-10), the two single-mode groups average 48.60 (carry-on only, range 27-78) and 49.67 (trainside checked only, range 31-73), and the four dual-mode lines average 76.75 (range 59-87) (see [Appendix JJ](#)). The presence of any service lifts a line roughly 43 points above the no-service floor, and offering both modes adds a further ~28 points on top of that.

A Snapshot in Time: The Airo Trainset Rollout

It's important to note that these statistics capture the network as it stands before the rollout of Amtrak's new Airo trainsets, which are poised to meaningfully improve scores on the lines receiving them. Because bike-space capacity is one of the heaviest-weighted indicators in the scoring framework (worth up to 50 points), even a modest increase in onboard bike racks can shift a line's overall score considerably. The *Vermont* offers a useful illustration of this dynamic.

The *Vermont* currently scores 51, with 30 of a possible 50 points on the bike-spaces indicator, reflecting an average of six bicycle spaces per trainset. The new Airo trainsets typically run in a six-car configuration—a locomotive plus five passenger cars—and each new passenger car comes equipped with a bicycle rack capable of holding two bikes.³⁵ Once the *Vermont* transitions to the Airo fleet, it will offer ten bike spaces per trainset (two spaces across five passenger railcars), which is enough to earn the maximum hardware score of 50 points (see [Appendix J](#)). The *Vermont*'s overall score is therefore projected to rise by 20 points to 71—moving the line out of the Moderate band (40–59) and into the Good band (60–79).

The *Vermont* is just one of many lines positioned to benefit. The *Cascades* line received its first Airo trainset in May 2026, which is expected to enter passenger service this fall.³⁶ The Airo rollout will continue to expand bicycle-carrying capacity across 14 additional routes in the years ahead.³⁷ In other words, the scoring presented above should be read as a baseline—a snapshot of where the network stands today—and as a useful benchmark for measuring the improvements the Airo rollout is expected to deliver.

35 Sachs, A. (2026, February 11). "Amtrak's Airo Trains Are Arriving Soon. Here's What to Expect." *The Washington Post*. <https://www.washingtonpost.com/travel/2026/02/11/amtrak-new-airo-trains/>

36 McLoon, A. (2026, May 16). "First Next-Generation Amtrak Cascades Train Arrives in Seattle." *KING 5 News*. <https://www.king5.com/article/news/community/transportation/next-generation-amtrak-cascades-train-seattle/281-65cc1d7f-8851-4e57-8892-7c73ae6f0570>

37 Amtrak. (2026). "Amtrak Airo Fleet." *Amtrak Media*. <https://media.amtrak.com/airo-fleet/>

Recommendations for Amtrak

Background: The 2024 Exchange Between the Amtrak Bike Task Force and Amtrak Leadership

The Task Force's March 2024 Letter

On March 6, 2024, Caron Whitaker—Coordinator of the Amtrak Bike Task Force—wrote to Amtrak chief executive Stephen J. Gardner on behalf of the coalition of local, state, and national cycling and tourism organizations that comprise the Task Force (see [Appendix AA](#)). The letter opened by highlighting the growing demand for bike-on-train travel: a 10.1% increase in bikes carried from FY22 to FY23, an 8.7% increase in bike-related revenues, and a notable \$718,403.57 contribution from bikes to Amtrak's total FY23 carry-on revenue of roughly \$3.5 million—about 20.4 percent. The Task Force framed the connection between Amtrak and active transportation as a critical element of a multi-modal transportation system and commended Amtrak for prior progress on policy transparency and expanded bike capacity on select routes.

The letter then advanced three recommendations for future improvements:

- 1. Equip the new Airo trains with more and better bicycle storage** on existing routes, and increase bicycle storage on new routes.
- 2. Make it easier for passengers to travel by bike** by (a) eliminating the requirement to remove a wheel for storage, (b) allowing more than one bike per car so passengers and their bikes can sit together, (c) ensuring bike hooks are at least four inches wide to fit a greater range of bicycle types and (d) ensuring new bike racks use materials and straps that minimize scratching and swaying, citing concerns raised in a February 2024 *Streetsblog* review of new Amtrak California equipment.³⁸
- 3. Simplify the customer ticketing experience** by limiting bike-transport fees to a single charge per itinerary, even when connecting—noting that in some regions, connecting passengers were paying nearly as much (or more) for bike service as for their own seat.

The letter closed by thanking Amtrak staff Mariah Morales and Derrick James for their partnership, expressing optimism about “an exciting future ahead,” and inviting continued collaboration.

Amtrak's May 2024 Response

On May 24, 2024, CEO Stephen J. Gardner replied on behalf of Amtrak (see [Appendix BB](#)). He opened by acknowledging the Task Force's contributions to recent progress, including the expansion of carry-on bike service across the Northeast Corridor and many state-supported routes, equipment modifications to better accommodate bikes on legacy fleets, prioritized assignment of Baggage Cars to high-demand long-distance routes, and improved customer-facing communications. He affirmed the more than 10% growth in bikes carried and emphasized the sustainability benefits of multi-modal bike-and-rail travel. Addressing the Task Force's specific recommendations in turn:

- 1. Bicycle storage on new Airo trains.** Each Airo coach car will include one baggage/bicycle tower accommodating two bicycles when used for bike transport. Some Airo trainsets will also include a baggage compartment with additional bike storage capacity (as checked baggage or self-service).
- 2. Easier travel with bikes.**
 - **Wheel removal:** The new Venture trainsets (for Midwest and California state-supported routes) and the Amtrak Airos will have sufficient space to store bikes without wheel removal, unlike the legacy equipment they replace.

38 Rudick, R. (2024, February 1). “Review: Amtrak California Passengers Are Starving for New Trains.” *Streetsblog San Francisco*. <https://sf.streetsblog.org/2024/02/01/review-amtrak-california-passengers-are-starving-for-new-trains>

- **Multiple bikes per car:** The new towers will hold three bicycles on Venture trainsets and two on Airos, increasing per-car capacity, though final allocation must balance carry-on luggage needs.
- **Bike hook width:** In response to stakeholder feedback during mock-up inspections, Amtrak increased Airo bike hooks from two inches to three inches—the largest size that fits within the tower configuration. This accommodates most mountain bikes other than those with oversized “fat tires,” falling short of the Task Force’s four-inch recommendation.
- **Securement materials and straps:** Amtrak stated it was not aware of securement or swaying problems on Venture cars beyond the 2024 *Streetsblog* report³⁹ and would continue to monitor customer feedback, while noting that improvements to state-owned equipment must be directed and funded by the owning states.

3. Single bike fee for connecting itineraries. Amtrak declined this recommendation, citing limitations of the Arrow reservations system and asserting that current bike charges compare favorably to air, bus, and shipping alternatives.

Gardner also outlined near-term initiatives expected to expand bike-carrying capacity, including the FY2024 return to service of 55 cars (six Viewliner Baggage cars, two Superliner Coach-Baggage cars, and 18 Horizon Coaches), standardization of bike and bike-luggage rack configurations across the Superliner Coach-Baggage fleet, and added *Northeast Regional* frequencies enabled by fixed-direction seating. New state-supported services between Chicago-St. Paul (the *Borealis*) and New Orleans-Mobile (*Mardi Gras*) were also expected to accommodate bikes.

The letter closed by tying future progress to two funding variables: annual federal appropriations, which support near-term bike-service improvements, and continued multi-year capital funding after the Infrastructure Investment and Jobs Act’s advance appropriations end in 2026. Gardner framed this funding as essential to replacing remaining legacy equipment with modern, bike-accommodating railcars and to Amtrak’s goal of doubling ridership by 2040.

Beyond the Train Car: The 2026 Letter to Amtrak President Harris

In the two years since that exchange, several of the conditions Gardner described have shifted. Amtrak’s leadership has changed, with Roger Harris now serving as President; the Airo trainsets have moved from design and mock-up into a more concrete delivery trajectory; and the IIJA funding cliff Gardner flagged in 2024 is now imminent. At the same time, the Task Force’s own priorities have evolved in response to Amtrak’s 2024 commitments. With the Airo investment now largely locked in—and with no comparable equipment redesign yet at the design stage where Task Force input could shape it, though the recently announced long-distance fleet replacement may reopen that avenue (see [Closing](#))—the Task Force has shifted its focus away from rolling stock specifications and toward the parts of the bike-travel experience that surround the train itself: how customers find bike-eligible service, how they book it, where they can board with a bike, and how bike carriage is priced across multi-segment trips. The Task Force’s June 2026 letter to President Harris, summarized below, reflects that shift. Because the letter was submitted shortly before this report’s publication, no formal response from Amtrak is yet available; any reply will be addressed in a future update (see [Appendix SS](#) for the full 2026 Task Force letter).

Amtrak Bicycle Task Force Letter to Amtrak President Roger Harris (July 2026)

In July 2026, the Amtrak Bicycle Task Force submitted a letter to Amtrak President Roger Harris commending the agency for the new Airo trains and their improved bicycle storage, and setting out recommendations to continue improving bicycle access across Amtrak’s network. Consistent with the shift in priorities described above, and recognizing that the Airo investment makes another major redesign of train cars unlikely in the near term, these recommendations focus on the parts of the trip that surround the train—finding bike-eligible service, booking it, station access, and how carriage is priced—rather than on rolling stock.

³⁹ Rudick, R. (2024, February 1). “Review: Amtrak California Passengers Are Starving for New Trains.” *Streetsblog San Francisco*. <https://sf.streetsblog.org/2024/02/01/review-amtrak-california-passengers-are-starving-for-new-trains>

2026 Letter's Key Recommendations

- 1. Website clarity:** Provide a clear, at-a-glance list of stations offering bike service, along with whether that service is carry-on or checked baggage.
- 2. Reservation system fixes:** Correct inconsistencies that allow bike tickets to be purchased for routes or return trips where bike service is unavailable. Additionally, establish a notification system to alert passengers with booked bicycle tickets when rail replacement buses are in service, as some buses cannot accommodate bicycles, giving travelers enough advance notice to make alternate arrangements.
- 3. Station expansion:** Prioritize adding bike service at high-potential, currently unstaffed stations, with three specific examples:
 - **Anniston, AL (ATN):** gateway to the ~100-mile Chief Ladiga/Silver Comet Trail corridor (*Crescent* line).⁴⁰
 - **White Sulphur Springs, WV (WSS):** access to the 78-mile Greenbrier River Trail⁴¹ and the Mon Forest Gravel Route Network (*Cardinal* line.)⁴²
 - **Greenville, SC (GRV):** less than half a mile from the Swamp Rabbit Trail, a regional tourism anchor generating ~\$6.7 million annually⁴³; already promoted by Amtrak on its *Crescent* page (see [Appendix PP](#)).⁴⁴

While the report argues elsewhere that carriage fees are a barrier best addressed through state subsidy on state-supported routes (see [page 32](#)), national lines have no subsidizing state, so for those routes, a mechanism that trades a modest premium for cost certainty and convenience may be more practical:

- 4. Bundled USA Rail + Bike Pass:** Offer a “USA Rail + Bike” pass—a premium tier of the existing USA Rail Pass that bundles bicycle carriage into the pass itself rather than billing it segment by segment. A traveler would pay a higher upfront price than the standard pass in exchange for the ability to bring a bike on every leg of the trip without a separate per-segment reservation or transaction. The add-on price could be set to recover Amtrak’s costs of bicycle carriage on national (non-state-supported) lines, where the agency does not receive a state subsidy; the same structure could optionally extend to state-supported routes. For Amtrak, this converts a frequent source of customer-service friction—repeated bike-fee transactions across a multi-segment itinerary—into a single, revenue-generating product, while giving cyclists cost certainty and a strong reason to choose the train for long-distance, multi-leg trips.

40 City of Anniston. (n.d.). “Chief Ladiga Trail.” <https://anniston.al.gov/chief-ladiga/>

41 Greenbrier River Trail Foundation. (n.d.). “Welcome to the Greenbrier River Trail.” <https://www.greenbrierrivertrail.com/>

42 Battle, N. (2026, April 10). “The Mon Forest Gravel & Bikepacking Route Network is Here!” Bikepacking Roots. <https://bikepackingroots.org/2026/04/mon-forest-gravel-bikepacking-route-network/>

43 Eat Smart Move More South Carolina. (2016). “Stronger Economies through Active Communities: The Economic Impact of Walkable, Bikeable Communities in South Carolina” (pp. 1-32). <https://townofblacksburgsc.com/wp-content/uploads/2020/12/How-Trails-Impact-Economic-Development.pdf>

44 Amtrak. (n.d.-e) *Crescent*. Amtrak. <https://www.amtrak.com/crescent-train>

Recommendations for Train Station and Platform Owners

Amtrak does not own the majority of the train stations it serves. Instead, the stations are mostly owned by local governments, state DOTs, transit agencies, or development associations.

In order to improve bicycle accommodations, train station owners should:

- Ensure safe, comfortable, and accessible passage from the street to the station.
- Provide secure, well-lit bike parking that is covered where possible and visible from the station entrance.
- Work with local bikeshare operators to place docks and bikes at the station.
- Post visible signage with:
 - » Instructions on how to bring your bike on board the train.
 - » Which stations on that train line also have bike access (since Amtrak doesn't currently publish this publicly, stations can fill this gap locally).
 - » An on-site or take-along bike map of the surrounding area, and contact information for a local bike organization (if applicable).
 - » Opportunities for bicyclists to make suggestions to improve bicycle service.
- Coordinate with the local government, Chamber of Commerce, and the agencies or organizations that manage popular destinations (such as tourism bureaus, downtown business districts, parks and trail authorities, or universities) to ensure on-street wayfinding from the station is clear, consistent, and accessible.
- Apply to become a Bicycle Friendly BusinessSM with the League of American Bicyclists, showcasing your adoption of these strategies and receiving customized feedback and a menu of recommendations to continue improving your bike-accessibility.

For Unstaffed Stations

Owners should work with Amtrak to explore trainside checked bicycle service. As Prince, West Virginia (**PRC**) on the *Cardinal* line demonstrates, this is possible even without a staffed station.

Prince is not an isolated case. Amtrak has been steadily expanding bicycle service to unstaffed stations across its network, including stops on the *California Zephyr*, *Cascades*, *Crescent*, *Empire Builder*, *Carolynian*, and *Pere Marquette* lines (see [Appendix CC](#) for a comprehensive list).⁴⁵ This growing precedent demonstrates that bike service expansion at unstaffed stations is both feasible and increasingly common, giving station owners a strong foundation for advocacy.

⁴⁵ Amtrak. (n.d.-b). "Answers to Your Questions About Bikes Onboard." <https://www.amtrak.com/bike-faqs>

See Case Study #1: Anniston, AL (ATN) Platform Extension

Anniston, Alabama, sits at the intersection of the *Crescent* line, Coldwater Mountain, and the Chief Ladiga Trail, positioning the city as a natural destination for rail-supported bicycle tourism. Historically, staffing limitations and a platform too short to efficiently accommodate bicycle loading prevented the introduction of bicycle service at the station.⁴⁶ However, local leaders, advocates, and businesses have continued investing in the infrastructure and partnerships needed to support future bike and rail connections. With Amtrak planning Americans with Disabilities Act-related station improvements, including a platform extension⁴⁷ targeted for completion in FY 2027,⁴⁸ Anniston (**ATN**) may be closer than ever to overcoming one of its major physical barriers to bicycle access. The full study in the report's "Case Studies" section traces this multi-year, multi-stakeholder effort and the lessons it offers about persistence, partnership, and the role communities can play in expanding multimodal access.

46 Hayes, D. (2015, November 13). "Bike-Friendly Amtrak Stops Include Birmingham and Tuscaloosa, But Not Anniston." *WBRC News*. <https://www.wbrc.com/story/30505248/bike-friendly-amtrak-stops-include-birmingham-and-tuscaloosa-but-not-anniston>

47 "Amtrak Fact Sheet: State of Alabama, Fiscal Year 2023" (pp. 1-4). (2024). Amtrak. <https://www.amtrak.com/content/dam/projects/dotcom/english/public/documents/corporate/statefactsheets/ALABAMA23.pdf>

48 "Amtrak in Alabama: Fiscal Year 2025" (pp. 1-4). (2026). Amtrak. <https://www.amtrak.com/content/dam/projects/dotcom/english/public/documents/corporate/statefactsheets/ALABAMA25.pdf>

Recommendations for Communities with Amtrak Stations

Bicycle travel can be a big economic boon to local governments. In Calhoun County, Alabama—home to the Anniston (**ATN**) station discussed in Case Study #1—the 39.5-mile Chief Ladiga Trail alone generated \$2.2 million in total economic output in 2023, contributing \$1.1 million to the county's GDP and over \$345,000 in local, state, and federal tax revenue.⁴⁹ The nearby Coldwater Mountain Bike Trail produces roughly \$1.8 million in new spending annually, with non-local users spending an average of \$138.49 per day.⁵⁰ Even single events compound the effect: the three-day 2021 Coldwater Mountain Fat Tire Festival generated more than \$131,400 in direct, indirect, and induced economic output for the county.⁵¹

Our first recommendation is to become a **Bicycle Friendly Community**SM, and pay special attention to:

- Ensuring safe and accessible bicycle infrastructure from the station to common destinations such as:
 - » Universities and colleges;
 - » Trailheads if the town is located along a longer trail route;
 - » Other tourist sites; and
 - » Downtown shopping areas.
- Make sure any local safety plan, bike plan, or other transportation plan includes improvements to these routes.
- In addition to the infrastructure, having a clear and accessible wayfinding system.
- Work with the train station owner to ensure easy-to-read bike maps are available, including routes to popular destinations.

Other Recommendations for Communities with Amtrak Stations

- If your station is currently unstaffed, advocate to Amtrak for bicycle service exceptions, citing the Prince, WV (**PRC**) precedent as a model.
- Communities near bikepacking routes (like the Greenbrier River Trail⁵² near White Sulphur Springs (**WSS**) in West Virginia, or those along the 3,500-mile Great Plains Gravel Route⁵³ from Texas to North Dakota) should make an especially strong case, since lack of bicycle service at nearby stations forces riders to detour dozens or even sometimes hundreds of miles (particularly in Texas).
- Advocate for bikeshare docks near the station, since, unlike in Europe (where national rail carriers often offer their own bikeshare fleet), no national bikeshare is integrated with Amtrak. Local governments and transit agencies fill this role, contracting with companies like Lyft and BCycle to operate bikeshare systems in their jurisdictions.

49 Green, J. (2024). "Economic Impact of Visitation to Recreation Trails in Calhoun County, Alabama: January 1, 2023 Through December 31, 2023" (pp. 1-24). Jackson State University's Center for Economic Development and Business Research. <https://anniston.al.gov/wp-content/uploads/2024/09/FINAL-CALHOUN-COUNTY-TRAILS-2023.pdf>

50 Boozer, B. B., & Self, M. (2012). "An Economic and Impact Analysis of the Coldwater Mountain Bike Trail" (pp. 1-73). Jackson State University's Center for Economic Development. https://headwaterseconomics.org/wp-content/uploads/Trail_Study_13-coldwater-mountain-bike-trail.pdf

51 Green, J., & Kelley, A. (2021). "2021 Coldwater Mountain Fat Tire Festival Economic Impact Assessment" (pp. 1-32). Jackson State University Center for Economic Development and Business Research. <https://anniston.al.gov/wp-content/uploads/2022/07/CWMBT-Fat-Tire-Festival-2021-Economic-Impact.pdf>

52 Greenbrier River Trail Foundation. (n.d.). "Welcome to the Greenbrier River Trail." <https://www.greenbrierivertrail.com/>

53 Bikepacking Roots. (n.d.). "Great Plains Gravel Route." <https://bikepackingroots.org/project/great-plains-gravel-route/>

Recommendations for Bicycle Friendly BusinessesSM, Tourism Bureaus, Local Economic Development, Business Improvement Districts, and Chambers of Commerce

If you are investing in bicycle tourism, consider working with Amtrak, train stations, and your local government to make train-bike travel easier.

- Advocate for bicycling infrastructure suitable for all ages and abilities, clear and visible wayfinding, and easy-to-find information on **Bicycle Friendly BusinessesSM**.
- Create a map of Bicycle Friendly BusinessesSM, bike parking, and trails that cyclists can pick up at the train station. Include bike routes from the station to those destinations. Advocate for your local station's website and for Amtrak to include the map on their website.
- Advocate for reduced or free bicycle carriage fees on state-subsidized Amtrak corridors, as ticket cost can be a barrier to would-be bicycle travelers—especially budget bikepackers.
- Recognizing that this can be a longer-term goal, consider whether the route to the station is safe—and where it is not, make safety improvements a stated priority in local transportation plans.

Bike Parking

One critical aspect of bike tourism is ensuring safe, secure bike parking and storage. It's hard to enjoy a good meal or shopping trip if you are worried about your bike. Work with the community and the business district to ensure there are ample end-of-trip facilities, including bike racks and public bike repair stations with air pumps, tools, and maintenance supplies.

For Hotels and Inns

Make sure you have indoor overnight bike parking—or at least bike parking that is covered, secure, visible from the main entrance, and well-lit at night. When you advertise for bicyclists or tour companies, make sure to mention you have indoor bike parking!

See Case Study #2: Spin-Capitol Corridor Payment Integration Pilot

Davis, California is piloting what may be the most frictionless first/last-mile integration yet attempted on an Amtrak line. Building on *Capitol Corridor's* 2023 contactless "Tap2Ride" payments rollout, the *Capitol Corridor* Joint Powers Authority, Spin, the University of California-Davis, and California Integrated Travel Project (Cal-ITP) are testing whether free bikeshare trips—conditioned on a confirmed rail ticket purchase and a geofenced trip endpoint at the Davis (**DAV**) station—can drive incremental rail ridership. Unlike rewards programs or promo codes elsewhere, the discount is essentially invisible to the rider. The trial begins in fall 2026. If it shows a causal ridership lift, the model offers a replicable template for any community trying to integrate bikeshare with intercity rail. The full study in the report's "Case Studies" section describes the technical components—account-based ticketing, brokered Application Programming Interface (API) integration, geofenced verification—that make it replicable.

Note on Budgeting and Bicycle Ticket Pricing

Spending levels vary considerably among long-distance bicyclists. On the more budget-conscious end, individuals often aim to spend between \$40 and \$50 a day on multi-day tours by opting for low-cost camping accommodations, limiting resupply stops, and cooking the majority of their own meals. At the other end of the spectrum are those who engage in what is sometimes called “credit card touring”—carrying limited food and gear, eating at restaurants for most meals, and staying in hotels or bed-and-breakfasts, with daily spending that typically exceeds \$150.

For budget travelers, bicycle carriage fees can add up to 20% to a trip's budget. Consider a four-day tour for someone planning to spend \$50 per day, for a total trip budget of \$200. If that traveler has to pay \$20 each way to bring their bicycle aboard Amtrak—\$40 round-trip—their \$200 budget balloons to \$240. By contrast, a “credit card” tourist spending \$150 a day on a four-day trip would see the same \$40 round-trip bicycle fee add only about 6.7% to their budget (\$640 versus \$600) [as demonstrated in the table below]. The same fee structure, therefore, disproportionately burdens the cost-conscious bicycle traveler, who is also typically the rider least able to absorb the additional expense.

Traveler Type	Daily Budget	4-Day Total	Bike Fee (Round-Trip)	New Total	Percent Increase
Budget Bikepacker	\$50	\$200	\$40	\$240	20%
“Credit Card” Tourist	\$150	\$600	\$40	\$640	6.7%

The disparity can be especially pronounced because Amtrak does not use the same reservation system for bike tickets as it does for passenger tickets. Whereas the passenger ticketing system applies dynamic, demand-based pricing, bicycle tickets prices remain static and are determined by one's start and end stations, as well as whether the line is state-supported (and subsidized at what level).⁵⁴ The result is that, in some cases, the fee to bring a bicycle on board can equal or exceed the cost of the passenger's own ticket, particularly when low-bucket value fares are still available on a given route.

54 Mathews, J. (2023, October 20). “Amtrak Fare Changes Are Good News for Passengers.” Rail Passengers Association. <https://railpassengers.org/happening-now/news/blog/amtrak-fare-changes-are-good-news-for-passengers/>

Why Focus on Bicycle Ticket Pricing?

When adapting the ECF criteria to the U.S. context, there were points that needed to be allocated to an existing category since the United States does not have the same system of rail carrier-operated bikeshare systems and the same multilingual landscape as the European Union (see [Appendix C](#) for detail on the redistributed points).

Bicycle Ticket Cost, by contrast, sits squarely within the sphere where individuals, advocacy groups, and organizations can drive change—and it is a concern the Amtrak Bike Task Force has flagged as particularly urgent. For some trips, the cost of bringing a bicycle can exceed the cost of the passenger's own seat, and this surcharge has discouraged bike travelers from taking the train at all. Across the Amtrak system, bicycle tickets cost \$20, \$10, \$5, or are free, with the variation driven largely by who manages the train and whether—and at what level—a state subsidizes carriage on a given route. On the Northeast Corridor and other national (non-state-supported) lines, Amtrak charges \$20 per bike, and travelers who must switch trains pay that fee for each leg of the trip. On state-supported routes, the price can range from \$20 down to zero, with the state DOT effectively subsidizing the cost (Amtrak still bills the state DOT the full \$20). North Carolina offers a clear illustration of what successful advocacy and state investment can achieve. On the *Piedmont*—which operates entirely within the Tar Heel state, connecting Charlotte (**CLT**) and Raleigh (**RGH**)—bicycle carriage is free on every train, between every pair of stations along the route. The *Carolinian*, which shares the same corridor but continues north to New York City, is free for bicycles only on the state-supported segment between Charlotte and Raleigh; the moment a traveler's trip extends north of Selma (**SSM**), the standard \$20-per-bike fee applies. Together, these policies transform routes that might otherwise carry a \$20 round-trip surcharge into ones with no marginal cost for bicycle travelers—at least for trips that stay within the state-funded portion of the network.⁵⁵

Because these prices are shaped by state-level policy and Amtrak partnerships rather than by fixed infrastructure, they are responsive to public pressure, legislative engagement, and coordinated advocacy. For travelers who live in a state that operates Amtrak trains, there is a direct opportunity to advocate for lower ticket prices (see [Appendix NN](#) and [OO](#) for a list of which lines are state-supported and long-distance [i.e., not state-subsidized], respectively). The Task Force is also investigating how to influence the price of bike tickets on the national Amtrak lines, so that states can shape the cost of bike storage on those routes as well.

Another advocacy angle the Task Force is exploring is Amtrak's reservation system itself: whether it can be updated to lower or eliminate the cost of a bike ticket on journeys that require travelers to take two trains. Allocating additional weight to this criterion, therefore, not only better reflects the financial realities facing American bicycle travelers but also highlights a lever that the cycling advocacy community is positioned to pull.

⁵⁵ North Carolina Department of Transportation. (2024, December 2). "Bikes on Board." NC By Train. <https://www.ncbytrain.org/passenger-services/Pages/bikes-on-board.aspx>

State-Level Legislative Landscape

As states from Colorado to Minnesota pass legislation aimed at reducing carbon emissions and vehicle miles traveled, there is an opening to promote bike travel by trains as a concrete action toward meeting those goals. Colorado's Greenhouse Gas Transportation Planning Standard, approved in 2021, requires the Colorado Department of Transportation and the state's five metropolitan planning organizations to meet binding GHG reduction levels at four target years through 2050, with mode shift toward transit, biking, and walking as a central compliance pathway.^{56 57}

Minnesota built on that model in 2023, enacting legislation that requires highway capacity-expansion projects to conform to statewide GHG and per capita vehicle-miles traveled reduction targets—or to be modified, halted, or offset through investments in alternatives such as transit and active transportation.^{58 59}

56 Colorado Department of Transportation. (n.d.). Greenhouse Gas (GHG) Program. <https://www.codot.gov/programs/environmental/greenhousegas>

57 Colorado Energy Office. (2021, December 16). Colorado Approves Nation-Leading Rule to Cut Greenhouse Gas Emissions by Shifting How It Plans the State's Transportation System. <https://energyoffice.colorado.gov/blog-posts/colorado-approves-nation-leading-rule-to-cut-greenhouse-gas-emissions-by-shifting-how-it>

58 Minnesota Department of Transportation. (n.d.). "Transportation Greenhouse Gas Emissions Impact Assessment." <https://www.dot.state.mn.us/sustainability/ghg-assessment.html>

59 Move Minnesota. (2024, July 1). How Move Minnesota is Leading the Nation to Curb Climate Pollution from Transportation. <https://www.move.mn.org/how-move-minnesota-is-leading-the-nation-to-curb-climate-pollution-from-transportation/>

For Individuals and Advocates

Individuals can work with any of the entities above to advocate for important changes. Specifically, individuals and advocates can:

- **Advocate for increased federal investment in Amtrak.** One of the key things the Amtrak Bike Task Force, and advocates around the country, can do is push for robust funding for Amtrak and train travel in general. If we want Amtrak to make changes to be more welcoming to bicycles, we need to advocate for them to have the resources to do so.

If You Have a Station in Your Community:

Advocate for your community to become a Bicycle Friendly CommunitySM

- Join your local bicycle advocacy organization and look at the League's Bicycle Friendly CommunitySM [page](#) to learn more.
- Attend local planning meetings and advocate for safe and accessible bicycling routes to and from the train station, including wayfinding.

Advocate for the train station to become a Bicycle Friendly BusinessSM

Push for stations to become Bicycle Friendly BusinessesSM focusing on bike parking, safe passage in and out of the station, and improved signage for bicyclists on how to bring their bike on the train.

- Create “Where to Ride” guides for cyclists interested in riding from the nearest Amtrak line. Ask station and platform owners to display these guides and to request that Amtrak feature them on the relevant line's webpage. The [Cascades](#) and [Pacific Surfliner](#) lines do this well, and each publishes such a resource on its official website (see the hyperlinks above for examples).

If Your State has State-Supported Amtrak Routes:

- Work with your state bicycle advocacy organization for changes such as reduced cost for bike tickets, more and better information on bicycling access on trains, etc.

See Case Study #3: Cola Town Bike Collective Wayfinding (Columbia, SC)

In late 2025, the Cola Town Bike Collective—a small nonprofit bike co-op—leveraged a modest health-focused mini-grant to pilot a downtown bike wayfinding program in partnership with the City of Columbia. The new green palmetto-and-bicycle signs explicitly name the Columbia Amtrak (**CLB**) station as a destination (0.8 miles, 5 minutes by bike), with dedicated turn signs pointing cyclists toward it. The intervention is small in cost but outsized in symbolic value: it reframes the train, in the public realm, as a legitimate part of the local transportation network. The full study in the “Case Studies” section contends that local cycling nonprofits—which already maintain route-finding tools, repair networks, and city-staff relationships—are well-positioned to serve as Amtrak's de facto last-mile partners in mid-sized cities, and it offers a replicable template: identify a nearby station, partner with the municipality on signage, and pursue a small grant from a public-health or active-transportation funder.

Look for Opportunities to Advocate Through the Amtrak Bike Task Force:

- Push for Amtrak to publicly map which stations offer bike service, since this information is currently not available on the Amtrak website—a gap that discourages ridership from those traveling with bicycles.
- When advocating to Amtrak or your state Department of Transportation, reference the European Cyclists' Federation's *Cyclists Love Trains* framework and the adapted criteria for Amtrak (and the U.S. context) from this report—each provides concrete, scored criteria (bike spaces, booking channels, website functionality, and cost) that give advocates specific targets to push for.

Case Studies

Three local stories illustrating the recommendations above.

Case Study #1: The Anniston Platform Extension (Anniston, AL)

A Local Case Study in Station-Level Advocacy

Anniston, Alabama, offers an instructive case study in how local communities, rather than the transportation operator itself, often drive improvements that make passenger rail more welcoming for people on bikes. The city's Amtrak station (**ATN**)—served by the *Crescent* line—sits at a strategic location for cycling: it is adjacent to the Coldwater Mountain mountain biking trails and now serves as the southern terminus of the Chief Ladiga Trail, which connects via Georgia's Silver Comet Trail to form the longest paved trail corridor in the country at roughly 105 miles.⁶⁰

Despite this geography, Anniston was excluded when Amtrak announced expanded carry-on bicycle service for the *Crescent* in 2015. Historically, Amtrak cited staffing limitations at Anniston's station as a barrier to providing bicycle accommodations.⁶¹ Unlike larger stations with checked baggage personnel, Anniston has operated without dedicated baggage staff, creating operational challenges for traditional bicycle handling procedures.

A more fundamental physical constraint also stood in the way: the station platform itself. At only 500 feet, Anniston's platform was shorter than the *Crescent* trainset. This required trains to perform a "double stop," unloading some cars before pulling forward to serve the remainder of the train.⁶² Such operations complicate boarding procedures and make the addition of bicycle service more difficult. Extending the platform has long been identified as one potential way to simplify operations and improve the feasibility of future bicycle accommodations.

Importantly, the Anniston railroad station—referred to locally as the Anniston Multimodal Center⁶³—is not owned by Amtrak. The city purchased the historic depot from Norfolk Southern Railway and rehabilitated it, meaning that improvements to the station have depended on strong local leadership and sustained community support.⁶⁴ Over time, local officials, advocates, and tourism partners have consistently viewed Amtrak not simply as a transportation service, but as a valuable economic development and tourism asset capable of bringing visitors and bike riders from places like Atlanta directly into the heart of downtown Anniston.

Even as the question of bicycle service remained unresolved, Anniston continued to build the surrounding infrastructure that makes the station a meaningful destination. After acquiring the final 1.4-mile right of way segment from Norfolk Southern in 2022, the city awarded a \$7.26 million construction contract to extend the Chief Ladiga Trail 6.5 miles directly to the Amtrak station.⁶⁵ The completed extension opened with a ribbon cutting on April 24, 2025, creating a direct connection between the nation's longest paved trail corridor and intercity passenger rail service.⁶⁶ The trail now ends at the station itself: a cyclist can roll off the Chief Ladiga and walk straight to the *Crescent* platform—yet there is still no bike service to and from Anniston.

60 Byington, P. (2025, April 25). "Anniston Celebrates Chief Ladiga Trail Extension Opening." *The Bama Buzz*. <https://thebamabuzz.com/anniston-celebrates-chief-ladiga-trail-extension-opening/>

61 Hayes, D. (2015, November 13). "Bike-Friendly Amtrak Stops Include Birmingham and Tuscaloosa, but Not Anniston." *WBRC News*. <https://www.wbrc.com/story/30505248/bike-friendly-amtrak-stops-include-birmingham-and-tuscaloosa-but-not-anniston>

62 Nunnally, B. (2018, December 19). "Amtrak Platform Extension Still in the Works, City Says." *The Anniston Star*. https://www.annistonstar.com/news/anniston/amtrak-platform-extension-still-in-the-works-city-says/article_402bf150-041d-11e9-8a20-0b956700fea7.html

63 City of Anniston. (n.d.). "Chief Ladiga Trail." <https://anniston.al.gov/chief-ladiga/>

64 Amtrak. (n.d.-f) Anniston, AL (ATN). "Great American Stations." <https://www.greatamericanstations.com/stations/anniston-al-atn/>

65 "Anniston Celebrates Chief Ladiga Trail Extension With Ribbon-Cutting Ceremony." (2025, March 24). *Calhoun Journal*. <https://calhounjournal.com/anniston-celebrates-chief-ladiga-trail-extension-with-ribbon-cutting-ceremony/>

66 Byington, P. (2025, April 25). "Anniston Celebrates Chief Ladiga Trail Extension Opening." *The Bama Buzz*. <https://thebamabuzz.com/anniston-celebrates-chief-ladiga-trail-extension-opening/>

Local stakeholders have built the supporting ecosystem in parallel. The Northeast Alabama Bicycle Association moved its headquarters to downtown Anniston in 2019 in anticipation of the trail's arrival.⁶⁷ Local businesses—including bicycle shops⁶⁸, cyclist-oriented lodging⁶⁹, and the Coldwater Mountain Brewpub⁷⁰—have embraced the area's growing identity as an outdoor recreation destination centered around both trail access and rail connectivity.

Today, new opportunities are emerging. Amtrak has advanced plans for Americans with Disabilities Act improvements at the Anniston station, including extending the platform to improve accessibility and passenger boarding.⁷¹ While these upgrades are being pursued primarily to meet ADA requirements, they may also help address one of the longstanding physical barriers that has complicated the introduction of bicycle service at the station.

Staffing considerations remain an important part of the conversation. Historically, the absence of checked baggage personnel has limited the ability to provide bicycle service at Anniston. However, local leaders have continually expressed a willingness to partner with Amtrak to explore practical solutions.⁷² The station is already staffed to support connecting bus operations,⁷³ and community stakeholders have indicated they would welcome opportunities to collaborate with Amtrak, including identifying and training local personnel who could assist with passenger and bicycle boarding procedures if needed.⁷⁴ This

67 Lockette, T. (2019, April 4). "Anniston Running, Biking Clubs Open Headquarters Downtown." *The Anniston Star*. https://www.annistonstar.com/news/anniston/anniston-running-biking-clubs-open-headquarters-downtown/article_ed4b73b6-5741-11e9-a96e-0b0b7ed454f6.html

68 Wig Wheels, a bicycle repair and rental shop located approximately half a mile from the southern end of the Chief Ladiga Trail in Anniston, has served trail enthusiasts for over two decades. Owner Patrick Wigley has noted that he opened the shop in anticipation of the trail's eventual extension into downtown.

Bowser, J. H. (2025, June 4). "Alabama's Chief Ladiga Trail: June 2025 Trail of the Month." *TrailBlog* by Rails to Trails Conservancy. <https://www.railstotrails.org/trailblog/alabamas-chief-ladiga-trail-june-2025-trail-of-the-month/>

69 Hotel Finial, a historic Queen Anne mansion-turned-boutique hotel in Anniston, has actively courted trail cyclists by installing in-room bicycle racks and a bike washing station, and markets itself as a base for Chief Ladiga Trail visitors.

"Anniston, Alabama-Cycling City USA!" (n.d.). *Hotel Finial*. <https://hotelfinial.com/uncategorized/anniston-alabama-cycling-city-usa/>

70 The Coldwater Mountain Brewpub occupies the historic Louisville & Nashville Freight House in downtown Anniston—a former rail facility now situated directly along the completed trail expansion. The April 24, 2025 ribbon-cutting ceremony for the Chief Ladiga Trail extension was originally planned for the portion of the trail outside the Brewpub, but an unexpected rainstorm moved the event inside, where roughly 100 attendees gathered to mark the trail's arrival in the city center.

Evancho, L. (2025, April 25). "A Ribbon Worth the Wait: Chief Ladiga Trail Extension Celebrated with Ribbon Cutting and VIP Dinner in Anniston." *Calhoun Journal*. <https://calhounjournal.com/a-ribbon-worth-the-wait-chief-ladiga-trail-extension-celebrated-with-ribbon-cutting-and-vip-dinner-in-anniston/>;

Home. (n.d.). Coldwater Mountain Brewpub. <https://www.drinkcoldwater.com/>

71 Amtrak's Phase 2 ADA improvements at Anniston are described as including a new platform with associated ramps, stairs, railings, and signage (Amtrak, 2024). The platform extension component is directly relevant to bicycle service: the existing 500-foot platform requires the *Crescent* to perform a double-stop, a logistical barrier that Amtrak has previously cited as a reason for excluding Anniston from bicycle service expansions on the route (Nunnally, 2018). A longer platform capable of accommodating the full train length would remove this constraint, potentially enabling the kind of roll-on service available at other *Crescent* stops. The ADA improvements are targeted for completion in FY 2027 (Amtrak, 2026).

"Amtrak Fact Sheet: State of Alabama, Fiscal Year 2023" (pp. 1-4). (2024). Amtrak. <https://www.amtrak.com/content/dam/projects/dotcom/english/public/documents/corporate/statefactsheets/ALABAMA23.pdf>;

Nunnally, B. (2018, December 19). "Amtrak Platform Extension Still in the Works, City Says." *The Anniston Star*. https://www.annistonstar.com/news/anniston/amtrak-platform-extension-still-in-the-works-city-says/article_402bf150-041d-11e9-8a20-0b956700fea7.html;

"Amtrak in Alabama: Fiscal Year 2025 (pp. 1-4)." (2026). Amtrak. <https://www.amtrak.com/content/dam/projects/dotcom/english/public/documents/corporate/statefactsheets/ALABAMA25.pdf>

72 "Lengthened Amtrak Platform Could Handle Bicycle Tourism, Anniston Officials Say." (2016, September 12). Southern Rail Commission. <https://www.southernrailcommission.org/media-coverage/2016/9/12/lengthened-amtrak-platform-could-handle-bicycle-tourism-anniston-officials-say>

73 The Anniston depot functions as a true intermodal facility, served by the city's bus system and acting as the interchange point for all of Calhoun County's Areawide Community Transportation System (ACTS) bus routes. The ACTS fixed-route system uses the Amtrak Station on 4th Street as its central transfer point.

Anniston, AL (ATN). (n.d.). "Great American Stations." <https://www.greatamericanstations.com/stations/anniston-al-atn/>;

"Public Transportation." (n.d.). The City of Anniston. <https://anniston.al.gov/public-transportation/>

74 Norris, A. Personal communication. June 10, 2026.

spirit of partnership reflects the community's broader belief that stronger rail connections can serve as a powerful economic development and tourism tool for Anniston and the surrounding region.⁷⁵

The Anniston experience illustrates an important lesson for communities seeking to improve bicycle access to passenger rail. Meaningful change often happens incrementally and through sustained local advocacy. Anniston does not currently offer bicycle service on Amtrak's *Crescent*,⁷⁶ but the community has spent years laying the groundwork for that possibility. The trails have been built. The station now sits directly at the end of one of the nation's premier long-distance cycling corridors. Local businesses, advocates, and public officials have embraced bicycle tourism and continue searching for ways to strengthen connections between rail and active transportation.

With ADA-related station improvements, including a platform extension,⁷⁷ targeted for completion in Fiscal Year 2027,⁷⁸ one of the major physical barriers to bicycle service may soon be addressed. Operational questions remain, but Anniston's response has not been to wait for someone else to solve them. Instead, the community has actively sought to be part of the solution, expressing a willingness to partner with Amtrak, contribute local expertise, and help identify workable approaches that expand access for people traveling with bicycles.⁷⁹ For communities across the country, Anniston demonstrates that improving bike and rail connectivity is not solely the responsibility of the railroad. It is often the result of local leadership and the persistent belief that a train station can be something more—an engine for tourism, economic opportunity, and the kind of connected mobility that Anniston's Multimodal Center was always meant to represent.

Case Study #1 Lessons

Anniston's experience offers four lessons for communities seeking to improve bicycle access to passenger rail:

- 1. Collaboration is essential:** most Amtrak stations are owned by host cities or railroads,⁸⁰ so improving bicycle access requires buy-in from multiple partners, not just Amtrak.
- 2. Local leadership sustains momentum:** regional organizations, MPOs, advocacy groups, and business leaders are often what keeps rail projects moving over long timelines.
- 3. Station access and bicycle infrastructure are mutually reinforcing:** bicycle service becomes more compelling when riders can safely reach the station; trail networks gain value when they connect to intercity rail.
- 4. Community posture matters:** Anniston shows that proactive partnership and willingness to problem-solve can move a station closer to offering bicycle service even before a formal program exists.

While Anniston does not yet offer bicycle service, its experience demonstrates that persistence, partnership, and community buy-in can steadily move a station closer to that goal.

75 Lark, T. (2023, August 30). "Anniston, Alabama: A City on the Move." *Business View Magazine*. <https://archive.businessviewmagazine.com/anniston-alabama/>; "Anniston, Alabama: The Model City." (2016, December 4). *Business View Magazine*. <https://archive.businessviewmagazine.com/anniston-alabama-the-model-city/>

76 Anniston, Alabama (ATN) is not one of the "Select Stations" which offers Trainside Checked Bicycle service on the *Crescent* line.

"Bring Your Bicycle Onboard." (n.d.). Amtrak. <https://www.amtrak.com/bring-your-bicycle-onboard/>;

Hayes, D. (2015, November 13). "Bike-Friendly Amtrak Stops Include Birmingham and Tuscaloosa, But Not Anniston." *Channel 6: WBRC News*. <https://www.wbrc.com/story/30505248/bike-friendly-amtrak-stops-include-birmingham-and-tuscaloosa-but-not-anniston>

77 "Amtrak Fact Sheet: State of Alabama, Fiscal Year 2023" (pp. 1-4). (2024). Amtrak. <https://www.amtrak.com/content/dam/projects/dotcom/english/public/documents/corporate/statefactsheets/ALABAMA23.pdf>

78 "Amtrak in Alabama: Fiscal Year 2025" (pp. 1-4). (2026). Amtrak. <https://www.amtrak.com/content/dam/projects/dotcom/english/public/documents/corporate/statefactsheets/ALABAMA25.pdf>

79 Norris, A. Personal communication. June 10, 2026.

80 Amtrak. (2021). "Stations Appendices: Amtrak's FY 2022-2027 Service and Asset Line Plans" (pp. 1-68). <https://www.amtrak.com/content/dam/projects/dotcom/english/public/documents/corporate/businessplanning/Amtrak-Stations-ALP-Appendix-FY22-27.pdf>

Case Study #2: Spin-Capitol Corridor First/Last-Mile Payment Integration Pilot (Davis, CA)

The *Capitol Corridor* is an 18-stop intercity passenger rail line connecting the Sacramento region to the San Francisco Bay Area, operated by Amtrak and managed by the *Capitol Corridor* Joint Powers Authority (CCJPA).⁸¹ Like many U.S. passenger rail services, *Capitol Corridor's* ridership was severely affected by the COVID-19 pandemic: against a Fiscal Year 2019 high of approximately 1.8 million passengers, the line did not hit the one-million-passenger threshold until FY 2024, and full pre-pandemic service levels were not restored until December 2025.⁸² Eager to accelerate ridership recovery, CCJPA has been experimenting with strategies to make the service more attractive and convenient—including, in 2023, becoming the first Amtrak-operated intercity rail line in the United States to accept contactless “open-loop” bank-card payments⁸³ through a pilot called Tap2Ride that uses Littlepay as its transit payments processor.^{84 85}

Building on that payments infrastructure, University of California, Davis (UC Davis) researchers—together with CCJPA, the shared micromobility operator Spin, and the California Integrated Travel Project (Cal-ITP)—designed a more ambitious experiment: a behavioral trial that uses pricing to test whether free first/last-mile micromobility trips can drive incremental rail ridership. This pilot project offers free bikeshare trips to and from the station for train ticket holders—representing the “closest to automatic shared micromobility discount for verified transit trip” yet attempted in the United States.⁸⁶ Whereas other domestic and international integrations on the same matrix offer either unverified rewards (e.g., Deutsche Bahn RAD+⁸⁷ and WMATA's free Capital Bikeshare trips⁸⁸) or discounts verified only by manual inspection⁸⁹ or geofencing alone,⁹⁰

81 *Capitol Corridor* Joint Powers Authority. (n.d.). “CCJPA Service.” *Capitol Corridor*. <https://www.capitolcorridor.org/ccjpa-service/>

82 Graham, V. (2025, October 15). “*Capitol Corridor* Ridership Hits 1.13 Million in FY2025.” *Capitol Corridor: Get on Board!* https://www.capitolcorridor.org/blogs/get_on_board/capitol-corridor-ridership-hits-1-14-million-in-fy2025/

83 For transit payments, closed-loop refers to payments that are limited to a branded card with limited interoperability, as the payment network is meant only for a single transportation authority; in open-loop, a wider variety of payment types are allowed—such as credit cards or debit cards, as well as mobile wallets—and allow for customers to use their preferred payment method across various transit systems.

A Ticket to Ride: Understanding the Differences Between Closed and Open Loop Transit Payment Systems. (n.d.). Mastercard Gateway. <https://www.mastercard.com/gateway/expertise/insights/difference-between-open-closed-loop-payment-systems.html>

84 Ehmsen, E. (2023, January 28). “*Capitol Corridor* Announces Pilot Program to Let Riders Pay Fares With Contactless Debit/Credit Cards.” *Capitol Corridor: Get on Board!* https://www.capitolcorridor.org/blogs/get_on_board/capitol-corridor-announces-pilot-program-to-let-riders-pay-fares-with-contactless-debit-credit-cards/

85 Balaban, D. (2022, August 18). “California Commuter Rail Agency Plans to Launch Open-Loop Payments.” *Mobility Payments: Intelligence Report*. <https://www.mobility-payments.com/2022/08/18/california-commuter-rail-agency-plans-to-launch-open-loop-payments/>

86 Bodenschatz, H. (2026, April 22). “Integrated Payments for Shared Micromobility First/Last Mile Access to Public Transit” [Presentation]. North American Bikeshare and Scootershare Association's Shared Micromobility Research Round-Up, Virtual.

87 Deutsche Bahn (DB) is Germany's national railway operator. DB's RAD+ is a free smartphone app that rewards cyclists by tracking kilometers ridden, which can be redeemed for discounts and rewards at participating partner businesses. While the program is designed to encourage combined bicycle-rail travel, RAD+ rewards are considered unverified in this context because the app does not require confirmation of a linked rail trip—a user need not purchase or use a train ticket to earn rewards.

Bahnhof.de. (n.d.). DB Rad+ App. DB Station & Service AG. <https://www.bahnhof.de/en/discover/radplus>

88 The Washington Metropolitan Area Transit Authority (WMATA) offers eligible Metro customers ten free 45-minute classic bike rides on Capital Bikeshare's network of 5,000+ bikes across 650 docking stations in the DC metro area. To qualify, customers must create or hold a mobile Smart Trip card and complete an online sign-up form; rides are credited to an existing Capital Bikeshare or Lyft account and must be redeemed within 30 days of activation. The benefit is described here as “unverified” because eligibility hinges on Smart Trip card registration and residential jurisdiction rather than on a confirmed transit trip, meaning the reward is not directly conditioned on demonstrated rail or bus use.

WMATA. (n.d.). “Let's Ride Together: Metro and Capital Bikeshare.” Washington Metropolitan Area Transit Authority. <https://www.wmata.com/ride/guides/bikes/capital-bikeshare.html>

89 Manual verification, as used in this matrix, refers to a process whereby a transit employee (e.g., a bus or rail operator) visually inspects a rider's proof of bikeshare usage—such as a printed or digital receipt—to confirm eligibility for a discount. This method is distinct from automated verification approaches such as geofencing or account-linked ticket confirmation.

Watkins, K. Personal communication. June 9, 2026.

90 Geofencing, as used in this matrix, refers to the use of GPS or similar location-based technology to create a virtual geographic boundary around a designated area—such as a transit station or bikeshare docking zone—that automatically triggers a discount or reward when a rider's device enters or exits that boundary, without requiring

the Davis pilot conditions its discount on both a confirmed rail ticket purchase and a geofenced trip endpoint (see the matrix below and [Appendix R](#)).⁹¹

Existing transit and shared mobility payment integrations

Bodenschatz, H. (2026, April 22). Integrated Payments for Shared Micromobility First/Last Mile Access to Public Transit [Presentation]. North American Bikeshare and Scootershare Association's Shared Micromobility Research Round-Up, Virtual.

		Verification of transit usage		
		No verification	Manual verification/geofencing	Verification by transit ticket purchase
Discount/rewards structure	Unlock capability or shared payment system/pass (no discount)	LA Metro TAP card Clipper card SMART (Sonoma-Marin) KCATA (Kansas City)		
	Accrue transit or local business rewards/credits	Deutsche Bahn RAD+	Palo Alto Bike Love	Seattle Miami-Dade County
	Earn day pass or limited number of no-cost rides	WMATA (DC)	SMM trips: RBA/Redding Bikeshare Transit trips: SacRT (Sacramento)	COMET (Columbia, SC)
	Automatic discount on qualifying first/last mile ride		RTD (Denver) DART (Dallas)	UC Davis SPIN- <i>Capitol Corridor</i> pilot

The research design pairs this real-world integration with a behavioral trial scheduled to begin in fall 2026. A subset of study participants will receive free qualifying Spin trips to and from the Davis station (**DAV**), and their *Capitol Corridor* usage will be compared with that of a control group that does not receive the subsidy.⁹² The broader project—funded by the National Center for Sustainable Transportation⁹³—is explicitly framed around the question of whether shared micromobility, when treated and priced like public transit, can meaningfully address the first- and last-mile problem that has long limited rail uptake in lower-density California corridors.⁹⁴ The Davis context is particularly well-suited to the experiment: since fall 2023, Spin has operated e-bikes and e-scooters across the city under a joint city-university agreement,⁹⁵ and the program now offers up to 1,000 electric micromobility devices⁹⁶—giving the pilot a mature network to draw upon.

manual inspection of proof of transit use. Two programs in this matrix use this approach. The Palo Alto Transportation Management Association's Bike Love program verifies trips by confirming they stop or start within geofences at 30 Caltrain stations and two Palo Alto job centers, then automatically credits an incentive to a reloadable Visa card. Denver Regional Transportation District's (RTD's) "First Mile Free" pilot uses geofencing to determine a trip's end location, providing the first mile of an e-scooter or e-bike ride free when a rider ends their trip at RTD's University of Denver or Decatur-Federal stations—with no discount code or additional action required. Geofencing-based verification confirms proximity to a transit station rather than a confirmed transit trip, distinguishing it from the rightmost column of this matrix.

Burt, J. (2023, June). "Bike Love Rewards." Alternative Transportation Solutions. <https://altrans.net/bike-love-rewards/>;

DeMare, K. (2025, August 5). "RTD has a New Solution for the 'Last Mile' Problem: Scooters and E-bikes." *Denverite*. <https://denverite.com/2025/08/05/rtd-last-mile-program-free-scooter-ebike-rides/>

91 Bodenschatz, H. (2026, April 22). "Integrated Payments for Shared Micromobility First/Last Mile Access to Public Transit" [Presentation]. North American Bikeshare and Scootershare Association's Shared Micromobility Research Round-Up, Virtual.

92 Bodenschatz, H. (2026, April 22). "Integrated Payments for Shared Micromobility First/Last Mile Access to Public Transit" [Presentation]. North American Bikeshare and Scootershare Association's Shared Micromobility Research Round-Up, Virtual.

93 Watkins, K. Personal communication. June 9, 2026.

94 Watkins, K., Fitch-Polse, D. T., & Pike, S. (2024). "Envisioning Micromobility as Public Transit: Two Intervention Studies in the Living Lab of Davis, California." UC Davis Institute of Transportation & the National Center for Sustainable Transportation. <https://ncst.ucdavis.edu/project/envisioning-micromobility-public-transit-two-intervention-studies-living-lab-davis>

95 City of Davis, CA. (n.d.). Spin-Shared Micromobility. <https://www.cityofdavis.org/city-hall/public-works-engineering-and-transportation/bike-pedestrian-program/spin>

96 The Regents of the University of California, Davis campus. (2025, April 10). Spin Shared Micromobility Program. UC Davis Transportation Services. <https://transportation.ucdavis.edu/spin>

If the trial demonstrates a causal increase in rail ridership, the *Spin-Capitol Corridor* model could offer a replicable template for other regional rail operators seeking to grow ridership in the post-pandemic era—particularly because its core technical components (brokered API integration with Velocia, account-based ticketing via Littlepay, and geofenced trip verification) are increasingly standardized across California’s transit agencies through Cal-ITP. The pilot is also notable for what it avoids: rather than asking riders to opt into a complicated multimodal pass or remember a promo code, it leverages back-end data exchange to make the discount as close to invisible—and therefore as behaviorally frictionless—as possible. Whether that translates into measurable ridership gains is precisely the question the fall 2026 trial is designed to answer.

Case Study #2 Lessons

The *Spin-Capitol Corridor* pilot offers five lessons for rail operators and micromobility partners seeking to address the first/last-mile problem through integrated payments:

- 1. Frictionless beats feature-rich:** the pilot’s central design choice is to make the discount nearly invisible, relying on back-end data exchange rather than promo codes or multimodal passes. Lowering the cognitive and procedural cost of redemption may matter as much as the size of the discount itself in driving first/last-mile uptake.
- 2. Verification depth is a spectrum, not a binary:** by conditioning its discount on both a confirmed ticket purchase and a geofenced trip endpoint, the Davis pilot occupies the most rigorous cell in the integration matrix. Stronger verification reduces leakage to riders who aren’t actually connecting to rail, but it requires more mature payment and data infrastructure to execute.
- 3. Standardized infrastructure enables replication:** because the pilot’s technical components (brokered API integration via Velocia, account-based ticketing via Littlepay, and geofenced verification) are increasingly common across California agencies through Cal-ITP, the model is more portable than a one-off custom integration would be.
- 4. Existing micromobility maturity is a precondition:** the experiment is feasible partly because Davis already had a robust Spin network of up to 1,000 devices operating under a joint city-university agreement. Agencies without an established shared-micromobility presence would need to build that foundation before a comparable integration could succeed.
- 5. Rigorous evaluation distinguishes a pilot from a program:** the paired behavioral trial with treatment and control groups is designed to test for a causal ridership effect, not just measure usage. Building evaluation into the design from the outset is what will allow other operators to judge whether the model is worth adopting.

While the *Spin-Capitol Corridor* pilot has not yet produced ridership results, its design demonstrates that pairing standardized payment infrastructure with frictionless, verified incentives—and a rigorous test of their effect—can offer a replicable template for rail operators seeking to solve the first/last-mile problem.

Case Study #3: Cola Town Bike Collective's Bike Wayfinding Initiative (Columbia, SC)

The Cola Town Bike Collective (CTBC) is a 501(c)(3) community bike shop that provides low and no cost bicycles, repair services, and access to transportation for people in need.^{97 98} Over the past decade, CTBC has expanded beyond direct service work and increasingly serves as an advocate for safer, more connected, and easier to navigate walking and biking infrastructure across the Midlands region of South Carolina.⁹⁹

In 2025, CTBC partnered with the City of Columbia's Planning and Public Works departments to pilot a downtown bicycle wayfinding system designed to help people more easily navigate the city by bike, using a small health-focused mini-grant.^{100 101} The project installed green bicycle wayfinding signs along several of Columbia's most important low stress corridors. The signage system connects major destinations in Columbia, including the University of South Carolina, the Vista district, Five Points, Finlay Park, and the South Carolina State House. Signs display both mileage and estimated travel times by bike, helping reinforce the idea that many destinations in Columbia are closer and more accessible than residents may realize, and how to navigate Columbia by bike in a low-stress manner.

A major focus of the pilot for local advocates was intentionally integrating the Columbia Amtrak station (**CLB**) into the city's emerging bike network. The station is now signed as a destination throughout downtown, including directional turn signage guiding riders directly to the facility. From much of downtown Columbia, the station is less than one mile away and reachable within a five minute bike ride. Several recent infrastructure and planning efforts have also helped reconnect the station to the surrounding city in ways that better support people walking and biking. In 2022, the Greene Street bridge project significantly improved connections between downtown Columbia, the University of South Carolina, and the riverfront corridor adjacent to the station.¹⁰² Today, Greene Street functions as one of Columbia's most important east-west bike and pedestrian corridors, passing within half a block of the Amtrak station itself.

The station also now sits adjacent to the future Waterfront redevelopment area along the Congaree River, where the City of Columbia is planning a major regional waterfront park investment expected to total more than \$100 million over the next 10 years through phased park construction, trail expansion, and public space improvements.¹⁰³ The future park will serve as a central hub of the expanding Three Rivers Greenway network, a planned 27+ mile regional greenway system connecting downtown Columbia to Lake Murray and communities throughout the Midlands.^{104 105} As these projects move forward, the area surrounding the station is rapidly evolving into one of the most walkable and bike accessible districts in Columbia and South Carolina while also creating significantly stronger regional multimodal access to Amtrak.

97 Cola Town Bike Collective. (2026). "Making a Difference, One Bike at a Time." <https://colatownbikes.com/>

98 Kowsky, J. (2024, January 3). "Trip Recap: Cola Town Bike Collective Bike Overnights." Adventure Cycling Association. <https://www.adventurecycling.org/blog/trip-recap-cola-town-bike-collective-bike-overnights/>

99 Cola Town Bike Collective. (2026). "Making a Difference, One Bike at a Time." <https://colatownbikes.com/>

100 The grant to Cola Town Bike Collective was provided by Wholespire—a South Carolina nonprofit, formerly Eat Smart Move More South Carolina—that distributes Healthy Eating, Active Living (HEAL) mini-grants funded by the BlueCross BlueShield of South Carolina Foundation.

101 Wholespire. (2024, June 3). "Healthy Eating and Active Living Mini-Grant: Request for Proposals." <https://wholespire.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/05/2024-HEAL-MiniGrant-RFP-1.pdf>

102 Bolin, A. (2022, December 8). "Richland County Celebrates Opening of Greene Street Bridge." *Cola Daily*. https://www.coladaily.com/local_government/richland-county-celebrates-opening-of-greene-street-bridge/article_b5dfced8-7676-11ed-9c00-bbcf4e8194e5.html

103 Hughes, M. (2026, April 3). "From 'No-Man's Land' to Park? Columbia Gives First Look at Riverfront Designers." *The State*. <https://www.thestate.com/news/local/article315266182.html>

104 City of Columbia, South Carolina. (2026, January 23). "City of Columbia Advances Vision for Future Riverfront Park with Design Team Approval and Historic Philanthropic Gift by the Boyd Foundation." <https://columbiasc.gov/city-of-columbia-advances-vision-for-future-riverfront-park-with-design-team-approval-and-historic-philanthropic-gift-by-the-boyd-foundation/>

105 Hughes, M. (2026, April 29). "Columbia Plans \$60 Million in New Downtown Greenways." *The State*. <https://www.thestate.com/news/local/article315564222.html>

This is a small intervention with outsized symbolic and practical value: the staffed Columbia station (**CLB**) is currently served by Amtrak's *Floridian* route—a temporary merger of the *Silver Star* and *Capitol Limited* that links Chicago and Miami via Washington, D.C.—and Amtrak permits checked or carry-on bicycles at staffed stations, depending on the line's bike services offered (trainside checked, in the case of the *Floridian*).^{106 107} By naming the station on bike signage, the Collective is reinforcing in the public realm something most Columbia residents may never have considered: that the train is a legitimate, accessible part of the local transportation network, and that a bicycle is a reasonable way to reach it.

Case Study #3 Lessons

The Cola Town Bike Collective's wayfinding initiative offers four lessons for advocates and rail operators seeking to strengthen bicycle access to stations in mid-sized cities:

- 1. Station access doesn't require capital projects:** a community organization, a modest \$3,000 health-focused mini-grant, and a cooperative city public works department produced visible, durable infrastructure that explicitly markets the station to a new mode. Meaningful improvements can come from signage and partnerships rather than waiting on Amtrak capital investment. Columbia's staffed station (**CLB**), currently served by Amtrak's *Floridian* route, offers trainside checked bicycles.
- 2. Local cycling nonprofits are natural last-mile partners:** groups like CTBC already maintain route-finding tools, repair networks, and advocacy relationships with city staff, positioning them to serve as Amtrak's de facto last-mile partners in mid-sized cities where the carrier has a limited local presence. CTBC's broader work—including spearheading the opening celebration of South Carolina's first protected bike lane, which drew state legislators, city and county council members, and congressional staff—demonstrates the political reach and coalition-building capacity that make these groups effective partners well beyond any single project.¹⁰⁸
- 3. The model is replicable:** identify a station within reasonable cycling distance of downtown, partner with the municipality on signage in the public right-of-way, and pursue a small grant from a public-health, active-transportation, or community-foundation funder rather than waiting on transportation-specific capital programs. The template travels well to other mid-sized cities.
- 4. Amtrak can accelerate these efforts:** the railroad could meaningfully support local initiatives by maintaining a clearinghouse of partner organizations, providing standardized station-access bike wayfinding guidance, and recognizing local groups that successfully integrate stations into bike networks.

A small intervention with outsized symbolic and practical value, the CTBC wayfinding initiative demonstrates that community organizations, modest grants, and municipal cooperation can reframe the train station as a legitimate, accessible part of a city's bike network—even where Amtrak's own local footprint is minimal.

106 Amtrak. (n.d.). "Columbia, SC (CLB)." <https://www.amtrak.com/stations/clb>

107 Amtrak. (n.d.-c). "Bring Your Bike on Amtrak." <https://www.amtrak.com/bring-your-bicycle-onboard>

108 Townsend, M. (2025, August 18). "First 'Show Congress' Microgrant Celebrates South Carolina's First Protected Bike Lane." The League of American Bicyclists. <https://bikeleague.org/first-show-congress-microgrant-celebrates-south-carolinas-first-protected-bike-lane/>

Highlighting the Ongoing Work of Task Force Member Organizations

Adventure Cycling Association

The Adventure Cycling Association is a national nonprofit organization whose mission is to inspire, empower, and connect people to travel by bicycle. Founded in 1973, the organization develops and stewards long-distance bicycle routes across the United States, including the Adventure Cycling Route Network and the U.S. Bicycle Route System (USBRS), a growing national network of more than 24,000 miles of designated routes created in partnership with state departments of transportation and local agencies.



Reliable passenger rail service is an important component of this national network. Many riders rely on Amtrak to access route segments, connect rural communities, and begin or conclude long-distance trips. Clear policies, adequate onboard bicycle capacity, and accessible station infrastructure make multimodal travel predictable and practical.

Improved bicycle access on passenger rail expands equitable travel options, supports rural tourism economies, and reduces reliance on personal vehicles. Integrating rail service with the nation's growing bicycle route network strengthens mobility and sustainable transportation nationwide.

Bikepacking Roots

[Bikepacking Roots](#) is a national 501(c)(3) non-profit dedicated to supporting and advancing bikepacking, the growth of a diverse bikepacking community, and access to and the conservation of the landscapes and public lands through which we ride. We organize our [advocacy work](#) across three key themes: Facilitating the Bikepacking Experience, Balancing Conservation and Access, and Supporting an Inclusive & Diverse Bikepacking Community.



Through our advocacy work to **"Facilitate the Bikepacking Experience,"** we aim to lower barriers to bikepacking by improving and expanding camping options for cyclists and by supporting efforts to make travel to bikepacking destinations easier. We want to offer more options for bikepackers to reach bikepacking routes in ways that reduce reliance on car travel. As members of the Amtrak Bike Task Force, we advocate for improvements in bike travel by train to expand access to more bikepacking routes across the country. We are also focusing on developing more bikepacking routes closer to cities and in suburban areas, or accessible by public transportation.

Our [Route Network](#) consists of over 33,000 miles of mixed-surface bikepacking routes across the United States and continues to grow each month. Many of these routes are currently supported by Amtrak or could be. Here are two examples of the types of routes that we promote, and where they are supported by the presence of Amtrak or hindered by the lack of bicycle service at stations on or near the route.

Long-distance point-to-point bikepacking routes

- [The Pony Express Bikepacking Route](#) is a 2,200-mile route that traces the historic route from St. Joseph, Missouri, to Sacramento, California. Many riders who complete the full journey use Amtrak stations in Kansas City (*Southwest Chief*) and Sacramento (multiple lines).
- [The Great Plains Gravel Route](#) is our newest long-distance route, stretching 3,500 miles from the border with Mexico to the border with Canada. While Amtrak bike service is available near the Northern terminus of the route (Williston, ND-*Empire Builder*), there are several stations along the route in Texas (Alpine, Sanderson, Del Rio), but none of these have bicycle service. Instead, riders would have to take a train to El Paso and add several hundred miles of riding (on a busy paved highway) to their trip to connect with the route.

Destination Route Networks

- Our latest route network project, the [Mon Forest Gravel and Bikepacking Route Network](#), comprises over 40 routes in the Monongahela National Forest in West Virginia to support the economic development of towns adjacent to the Forest. The National Forest is served by an Amtrak Station, White Sulphur Springs (*Cardinal*), that does not currently have bicycle service. White Sulphur Springs is also situated along the [Greenbrier River Trail](#), a stunning 78-mile rail trail appealing to cyclists of all ages, levels, and abilities.
- With expanded Amtrak service, this route network and river trail could be enjoyed by hundreds more visitors every year, just as they enjoy the C&O Canal Trail and the Great Allegheny Passage by bike and train on the *Floridian* line. Prince, WV, is an example of a recent expansion of bicycle service to an unstaffed station along the *Cardinal* line, and we hope the same can be done for White Sulphur Springs in the future to open the gateway to the Mon Forest Route.

To look at examples of a rider using Amtrak to facilitate a ride on the Pony Express Route, see [Appendix V](#).

East Coast Greenway Alliance

Founded in 1991, the East Coast Greenway Alliance (“the Alliance”) leads the development of the East Coast Greenway (ECG)—a 3,000-mile multi-use trail from Maine to Florida. Working from early planning through ribbon cuttings, the Alliance partners with communities to secure funding, share trail-building expertise, and connect efforts across city, county, and state lines. The East Coast Greenway is a nationally-connected, locally-rooted trail system, linking 15 states and more than 450 communities. It strengthens local economies and transforms daily mobility and outdoor recreation by promoting healthy, sustainable transportation, and deeper connections to community and nature across the Eastern Seaboard.



Amtrak—along with local and regional transit—plays key roles in the vision of the East Coast Greenway: ensuring that all types of trail users are able to use Amtrak and transit to access segments of the ECG, whether close to home or far from home. In particular, long-distance and multi-day trip users rely on Amtrak to get them to their starting point along the Greenway or to help them get back home after their trip. Increased bicycle capacity in Amtrak cars, as well as clear, safe connections from stations to trails, are crucial to the growth of ECG use. And more reliable trail access along Amtrak routes means that people can use the East Coast Greenway without relying on cars. The East Coast Greenway Alliance will continue to advocate for strengthening Amtrak policies on bicycle access and trail connectivity for ECG users, as well as for other active transportation networks connected to train stations and transit stops.

To see East Coast Greenway Alliance staff embark on Amtrak’s Carolinian service with bicycles for a “Cross Triangle” ride, see [Appendices W](#) and [X](#).

Rails to Trails Conservancy

At Rails to Trails Conservancy, we are building a nation connected by trails. We reimagine public spaces to create safe ways for everyone to walk, bike, and be active outdoors.



Since 1986, RTC has worked to bring the power of trails to more communities across the country, serving as the national voice for the [rail-trail movement](#). With a grassroots movement more than 1 million strong, 42,500+ miles of multiuse trails on the ground, and hundreds of developing trail networks reaching people in every state, our focus is on building a future where trails connect everyone, everywhere. Our flagship initiatives—the [Great American Rail-Trail](#)®, [TrailNation](#)™, and [TrailLink.com](#)™—bring that strategy to life, connecting millions of people by trail.

Here's how RTC turns vision into reality:

- WE ADVOCATE for transformative programs and investments in trails, walking, and bicycling at the federal, state, and local levels;
- WE MOBILIZE people across the United States to advocate for safe walking and biking infrastructure in their communities and beyond;
- WE COLLABORATE with thousands of partners, including national organizations, federal, state, and local agencies, public leaders, and grassroots advocates, to create and connect trails and trail networks;
- WE CONNECT people and places by developing trail networks that create healthy, thriving communities and serve as models for the nation;
- WE SUPPORT OUR NATIONAL TRAIL COMMUNITY by providing best practices and trail planning resources, technical support, and capacity-building grants to communities of every shape and size seeking to create and connect joyful, vibrant, equitable, and inclusive public spaces;
- WE PROTECT TRAILS by continuing to lead a decades-long effort to shape the legal framework around rail-trails and defend them in the courts; and
- WE ELEVATE the transformative power of trails, building demand for this infrastructure and encouraging people to make trails part of their everyday lives.

To see how trails and passenger rail combine for both recreation and destination travel, read RTC's paired features on five Amtrak stations along the [Great American Rail Trail](#) and [five more across the South](#).

Cola Town Bike Collective

The Cola Town Bike Collective is a community bicycle organization based in Columbia, South Carolina, dedicated to making cycling accessible, practical, and welcoming for everyday people. Through education, community events, and infrastructure advocacy, the Collective works to grow Columbia's bike culture and connect residents to the city's growing bicycle network.



In partnership with the City of Columbia's Planning and Public Works departments, and with support from a grant from Wholespire, the Collective recently piloted a bike wayfinding signage program in downtown Columbia. New green wayfinding signs—featuring South Carolina's iconic palmetto tree alongside a bicycle symbol—were installed along Lincoln Street from Colonial Life Arena through the Vista neighborhood to Finlay Park, as well as on Greene, Lady, Pendleton, and South Main Streets. The signs display distances and estimated riding times to key destinations around the city, and critically, the Columbia Amtrak station (**CLB**) is included as a named destination. Dedicated turn signs pointing cyclists directly toward the Amtrak station were installed as part of the pilot as well.

The Collective identified a major barrier to cycling in Columbia as simply not knowing which streets offer lower-stress routes around town. This signage addresses that gap in a simple, low-cost way, helping everyday people navigate the network with confidence and discover that key destinations—including intercity rail—are closer by bike than they might think. The signs also serve as a reminder that taking a bike on the train from Columbia is possible, a connection the Collective plans to promote more actively in the coming months.

The pilot installation is now essentially complete, with enough materials remaining to expand to additional routes in the future. The Cola Town Bike Collective will continue advocating for stronger bicycle-rail connections in Columbia and for the infrastructure improvements that make multimodal travel practical for all residents.

To see examples of the signage, see [Appendix Y](#).

Palmetto Walk Bike

Palmetto Walk Bike is South Carolina's statewide advocate for safe, accessible, and connected walking and biking. Since 1995, the organization has advanced policies, funding, and partnerships that make it easier for people to safely walk, bike, and roll across the state.¹⁰⁹



Passenger rail is a natural extension of this mission. While South Carolina is served by four Amtrak routes, limited bicycle access creates barriers for residents and visitors who want to combine rail travel with the state's growing network of trails and bike routes.

As a member of the Amtrak Task Force, Palmetto Walk Bike supports expanded bicycle accommodations on passenger rail and at stations, as well as safe streets and last-mile connections that make bike-and-train travel a practical transportation option for South Carolinians.

¹⁰⁹ Palmetto Walk Bike. (n.d.). "About Us." <https://palmettowalkbike.com/about/>

Closing

When the League agreed in 2022 to host the Amtrak Bicycle Task Force, our goal was a practical one: to make traveling with your bike on American passenger rail easier. The benchmark came later. When the European Cyclists' Federation published its *Cyclists Love Trains* report, we saw a chance to build the same kind of baseline here—and, with it, to finally ask a question that had never had a real answer: how welcoming to bicyclists is American passenger rail, really? Four years and forty-six scored lines later, the answer is more heartening—and more complicated—than we expected.

It is heartening because the top of the American chart looks a little bit like the European one. The *Cascades* and *Gold Runner* services scored 87 and 86 out of 100 using criteria adapted from the European Cyclists' Federation, nearing the 88-point marks earned by Belgium's and Switzerland's national railways in the 2025 *Cyclists Love Trains* report. It is promising because the demand has been there all along: as of September 2020, more than 230,000 bikes had traveled with their riders on Amtrak since the carry-on bicycle program launched in October 2015, generating more than \$1 million in revenue in just under five years—a quiet but durable signal that, when the service exists, riders use it.¹¹⁰ It is a cause for optimism because Amtrak's Airo rollout—the largest fleet replacement since 1971¹¹¹—will, line by line, lift services like the *Vermont*

out of the “Moderate” tier and into “Good,” while doubling bike capacity in many cases and finally retiring the front-wheel-removal requirement that has long discouraged riders (especially those with mobility issues or loaded-touring bikes). And it is significant because Amtrak met its Task Force partners halfway on the Airo design at exactly the moment when a once-in-a-lifetime federal investment made such an alignment of priorities possible.

The Airo fleet is not the last opportunity of its kind. In May 2026, Amtrak announced next steps toward replacing its long-distance fleet—the overnight, cross-country equipment that still underpins some of the lowest-scoring lines in this benchmark, among them the *Floridian*, the *City of New Orleans*, and the *Texas Eagle*. Amtrak Senior Director of External & Regulatory Affairs Mariah Morales has called that replacement “a once-in-a-generation opportunity to transform overnight and cross-country rail travel,” one in which “a standardized, single-level fleet will improve reliability, simplify maintenance and allow us to deploy equipment more flexibly across the network.”¹¹² The Task Force pressed for bike capacity in the Airo design at exactly the right moment and the long-distance fleet replacement is the next such moment to build consistent bicycle storage into the routes that have the least of it today.

110 Abrams, J., & Toll, B. (2020, September 3). “Amtrak Expands Carry-On Bike Program on Northeast Regional and Northeast State-Supported Trains.” *Amtrak Media*. <https://media.amtrak.com/2020/09/amtrak-expands-carry-on-bike-program-on-northeast-regional-and-northeast-state-supported-trains/>

111 Bardolf, D. (2026, February 14). “Amtrak Adding Over 80 New Trains in Massive Overhaul of Fleet; Travelers React.” *Fox News*. <https://www.foxnews.com/travel/amtrak-adding-over-80-new-trains-massive-overhaul-fleet-travelers-react.amp>

112 Apicella, A. (2026, May 21). “Railway Interchange 2026 Session Sneak Peek: An Amtrak and Supplier Industry Roundtable.” *Railway Supply Institute*. <https://www.rsiweb.org/railway-interchange-2026-session-sneak-peek-an-amtrak-and-supplier-industry-roundtable/>

A transformed fleet would be a significant step, but it would not be enough on its own. The average Amtrak line is still a long way from the Cascades, and the gaps that remain are not the kind a single entity can close. Ninety-seven percent of route-miles run on tracks Amtrak does not own. Only 13% of stations, 9% of platforms, and 7% of parking facilities sit under Amtrak's sole control.¹¹³ The *Vermont*, the *Cardinal*, the *Crescent*, and the *Floridian* pass through dozens of communities where the question of whether a cyclist can board, where they can lock up, and how they can get from the platform to the trailhead is answered not in Washington, D.C., but by a city public works department, a state DOT, a regional MPO, a chamber of commerce, or—as in Columbia, South Carolina—a small bike co-op with a public-health mini-grant and a good relationship with city staff.

That is the through-line of this report, and it deserves to be stated plainly: a bike-inclusive Amtrak is not Amtrak's project alone. The three case studies bear this out. Anniston's platform extension required a city, a regional rail commission, an MPO, and years of patience; the *Capitol Corridor's* payment-integration pilot required Amtrak, a joint powers authority, a university, a state mobility office, and a private bikeshare operator working in concert; Cola Town's wayfinding signs required a nonprofit, a planning department, and a foundation that funds healthy-eating-active-living grants—not transportation grants. None of these efforts waited for Amtrak to lead. All of them made Amtrak more useful.

The recommendations in this report are organized around that reality. For Amtrak, we ask for a publicly available, at-a-glance list of which stations offer bike service and what kind; for a reservation system that does not sell tickets for trips it cannot honor; for targeted expansions at Anniston, White Sulphur Springs, and Greenville, where the trail networks and local demand already exist; and for a bundled "USA Rail + Bike" pass—a premium tier of the existing USA Rail Pass that incorporates bicycle carriage into a single upfront price, giving cyclists cost certainty across multi-leg trips and converting repeated per-segment fee transactions into a single, revenue-generating product for Amtrak. For station and platform owners, we ask for safe approaches, secure parking, visible signage, and applications to the Bicycle Friendly BusinessSM program. For communities, particularly those with Bicycle Friendly CommunitySM designation, we ask for local safety and transportation plans that explicitly include safe, low-stress connections between the station and

downtowns, trailheads, campuses, and other key destinations. For businesses, tourism bureaus, and advocates, we ask for sustained pressure at the state level on carriage fees, for indoor bike parking at hotels, for wider tire clearance on future rolling stock, and for locally produced "Where to Ride" guides modeled on what the [Cascades](#) and [Pacific Surfliner](#) already do well.

None of this is hypothetical. The Greenbrier River Trail, the Mon Forest Gravel Route Network, the Great Plains Gravel Route, the Pony Express, the Chief Ladiga and Silver Comet, the Swamp Rabbit, the East Coast Greenway, the Chesapeake & Ohio Canal Towpath, and the Great Allegheny Passage—these are routes that thousands of riders already plan around by asking the question of where the train will let them off with a bike. When a station like White Sulphur Springs (**WSS**) lacks bicycle service, riders do not give up the trip; they drive. When a station like Prince, West Virginia (**PRC**), finds a way to offer trainside checked service without staffing, riders take the train. The choice the rest of the network is making, one station at a time, is between those two outcomes.

The League's founding members were "wheelmen" who pushed for paved roads in 1880 because the bicycle was, at that moment, the most useful way to get between American towns. Nearly a century and a half later, the most useful way to get between many American towns and the trails, downtowns, universities, and protected lands beyond them is still—quietly, and increasingly—a bicycle paired with a train. Our work, and the work of every Task Force organization whose voice appears in these pages, is to make that pairing easier, cheaper, clearer, and available at more places on the map.

We hope this report serves as a benchmark and as an invitation. The benchmark is the score: forty-six lines, one framework, a way to measure progress against ourselves and against our peers abroad. The invitation is to everyone who reads it—Amtrak leadership, state DOTs, station owners, mayors, tourism boards, bike shops, advocates, and riders. The *Cascades* did not become an 87 by accident, and the lines currently scoring in the 40s and 50s will not improve by accident either. They will improve the way Anniston, Davis, and Columbia improved: one platform, one pilot, one sign, and one persistent local coalition at a time.

We look forward to writing the next version of this report with higher scores.

113 Amtrak. (2024a). "Amtrak 2024 Host Railroad Report Card and FAQs" (pp. 1-6). <https://www.amtrak.com/content/dam/projects/dotcom/english/public/documents/corporate/HostRailroadReports/Amtrak-2024-Host-Railroad-Report-Card.pdf>

Join Us

This report is not an endpoint—it is an invitation. The benchmark you've just read represents the collective effort of advocates, researchers, and organizations who believe that getting a bicycle onto a train should be simple, affordable, and reliable on every route in the country. That belief is what brought the Amtrak Bicycle Task Force together, and it is what continues to drive our work.

The Task Force is a coalition of national and local organizations committed to expanding and improving bicycle access across the Amtrak network. We bring together the perspectives of long-distance bikepackers, daily commuters, trail and greenway advocates, local bike collectives, and state and regional walk-bike groups. Our strength comes from that diversity—and from the simple fact that progress on bikes-on-trains happens when many voices push in the same direction.

If the findings in this report resonate with you—whether you run a bike shop near a station, coordinate a regional trail network, advocate at your statehouse, or simply love the freedom of pairing two wheels with the rails—there is a place for you in this work. Member organizations contribute expertise, local knowledge, and advocacy capacity; individuals can plug in through their local and state advocacy groups, many of which are already connected to the Task Force.

To learn more about the Amtrak Bicycle Task Force, get involved, or explore membership for your organization, reach out to the League of American Bicyclists.¹¹⁴ The next chapter of bicycle access on America's railways will be written by the people who show up. We hope you'll be one of them.

¹¹⁴ If interested, contact info@bikeleague.org to learn more about joining.

Appendices

Appendix A

ECF's Original Criteria

Hardware (60 points)

- **Bicycle Spaces (50 points):** the average number of spaces available for unfolded bicycles on an operator's long-distance trains.
- **Bicycle Sharing Schemes (10 points):** the existence and scope of bicycle sharing schemes or partnerships.

Software (40 points)

- **Bicycle Ticket Cost (10 points):** the cost of bringing a bicycle onboard, including both ticket prices and reservation fees (if applicable).
- **Booking Channels (10 points):** the number of channels through which a bicycle ticket can be bought, or a reservation can be made (e.g., website, app, ticket machines, station counters).
- **Languages (10 points):** the number of languages in which the operator provides information regarding bicycle carriage.
- **Website/App Functionality (10 points):** the user friendliness and functionality of the operator's website and mobile app for bicycle-related services.

Bonus/Minus Points (max. +10/-10 points)

- Additional services or restrictions by the operator related to the onboard carriage of bicycles.

Appendix B

Adapted Criteria

Hardware (50 points)

- **Bicycle Spaces (50 points):** the average number of spaces available for unfolded bicycles on the train line.

Software (40 points)

- **Bicycle Ticket Cost (10 points):** the cost of purchasing a bicycle ticket.
- **Reservation Requirement (up to 10 points):** whether or not an advance reservation is required to purchase a bicycle ticket or bring a bicycle onboard.
- **Booking Channels (10 points):** the number of channels through which a bicycle ticket can be bought, or a reservation can be made (e.g., website, app, or station counters).
- **Website/App Functionality (10 points):** the user friendliness and functionality of the operator's website and mobile app for bicycle-related services.

Station Access (10 points)

- **Station Staffing (10 points):** the proportion of stations along the line that are staffed, reflecting the practical accessibility of trainside checked bicycle service.

Bonus/Minus Points (max. +10/-10 points)

- Additional services or restrictions by the operator related to on-board bicycle carriage.

Appendix C

ECF Indicators Excluded from the Adapted Framework

Two indicators from the ECF’s original framework (see **Appendix A**)—bicycle-sharing schemes and multilingual service information—were not included in the adapted U.S. framework (see **Appendix B**), as neither is applicable to Amtrak’s operating context. Unlike many European national rail carriers, Amtrak does not operate or partner with a national bikeshare system; first- and last-mile bikeshare in the United States is provided by local governments and transit agencies contracting with operators such as Lyft and BCycle. Likewise, Amtrak operates in a primarily single-language service environment, making the multilingual-information indicator inapplicable. The points originally allocated to those two criteria were redistributed to the Reservation Requirements and Station Staffing indicators. Reservation Requirements received additional weight because booking flexibility is central to maximizing utility for the cyclist traveler—mirroring the ECF framework’s emphasis on maximizing flexibility for the user. Neither a reservation-required nor a walk-on model is treated as an outright best practice; both serve different travel styles and earn points accordingly, with the highest scores reserved for hybrid models that offer both reserved and unreserved bicycle spaces on the same service (see **Appendix M**). Station Staffing was used as a proxy for bike service availability—reflecting the degree to which staffed stations correlate with reliable bicycle handling, storage access, and on-the-ground assistance—based on discussions with Amtrak’s External & Regulatory Affairs team.

Appendix D

ECF's Original Bonus/Minus Indicators

[Note: Max. +10/-10]

Bonus

- Capacity over 10 spaces **(+2 points)**
- Capacity over 15 spaces **(+2 points)**
- Bicycles allowed on rail replacement buses **(+2 points)**
- Accommodates groups of cyclists if notified in advance **(+2 points)**
- Spaces with integrated bicycle locks **(+2 points)**
- Non-standard [adapted] bicycles allowed on board, such as tandems, tricycles, and recumbents **(+2 points)**
- Step-free train access across the entire fleet **(+2 points)**
- Luggage shipping service that accepts non-dismantled bicycles **(+2 points)**

Minus

- Strict peak time restrictions **(-2 points)**
- Surcharge for folded or bagged bicycles **(-2 points)**
- Strict weight restrictions (under 20 kg) [~44 lbs] **(-2 points)**
- Strict size restrictions (under 185cm) [~6 feet] **(-2 points)**
- Additional manipulation of bicycles is required before boarding, such as being required to turn the handlebars to 90 degrees **(-2 points)**

Appendix E

Adapted Bonus/Minus Indicators

[Note: Max. +10/-10]

Bonus

- Capacity of over 10 bicycle spaces **(+2 points)**
- Bicycles allowed on rail replacement buses **(+2 points)**
- Non-standard [adapted] bicycles allowed on board, such as tandems, tricycles, and recumbents **(+2 points)**
- Signage indicating which train car(s) can accommodate bicycles **(+2 points)**
- Accepts bicycles with tires wider than 2 inches **(+2 points)**
- Accepts bicycles with tires as wide as 4 inches **(+2 points)**
- Line provides resources on nearby bike-accessible trails **(+2 points)**
- Line offers both carry-on and trainside checked bicycle service **(+2 points)**

Minus

- Surcharge for folded or bagged bicycles **(-2 points)**
- Part of the route requires the bicycle to be stored in a box **(-2 points)**
- Additional manipulation of the bicycle is required for on-board storage [e.g., removing the front wheel, or turning handlebars to 90 degrees] **(-2 points)**
- Strict weight restrictions [under 40 pounds] **(-2 points)**
- Strict peak time restrictions **(-2 points)**

Appendix F

ECF's 2025 Bicycle Carriage Cost Indicator

- **10 points:** Free
- **9 points:** less than €2.50
- **8 points:** less than €5.00
- **7 points:** less than €7.50
- **6 points:** less than €10.00
- **5 points:** less than €12.50
- **4 points:** less than €15.00
- **3 points:** less than €17.50
- **2 points:** less than €20.00
- **0 points:** more than €20.00

Appendix G

Adapted Bicycle Carriage Cost Indicator

- **10 points:** Free
- **5 points:** \$5
- **2 points:** \$10
- **0 points:** \$20

Appendix H

ECF's 2025 Booking Channels Indicator

- **10 points:** 5 or more booking channels
- **8 points:** 4 booking channels
- **6 points:** 3 booking channels
- **5 points:** carriage is free and does not require a reservation
- **4 points:** 2 booking channels
- **2 points:** 1 booking channel
- **0 points:** 0 booking channels/not applicable

Appendix I

ECF's 2025 Bicycle Spaces Indicator

- **50 points:** 10 or more spaces
- **45 points:** 9 spaces
- **40 points:** 8 spaces
- **35 points:** 7 spaces
- **30 points:** 6 spaces
- **25 points:** 5 spaces
- **20 points:** 4 spaces
- **15 points:** 3 spaces
- **10 points:** 2 spaces
- **5 points:** 1 space/carriage possible, but the number is undisclosed
- **0 points:** Bicycle carriage is not allowed

Appendix J

Adapted Bike Spaces Indicator

- **50 points:** 10 or more spaces
- **45 points:** 9 spaces
- **40 points:** 8 spaces
- **35 points:** 7 spaces
- **30 points:** 6 spaces
- **25 points:** 5 spaces
- **20 points:** 4 spaces
- **15 points:** 3 spaces
- **10 points:** 2 spaces
- **5 points:** 1 space
- **0 points:** 0 spaces

Appendix K

ECF's 2025 Website/App Functionality Indicator

- Bicycle connection search tool in the online journey planner **(2 points)**
- One unified train journey planner **(2 points)**
- One unified webpage on bicycle carriage information **(2 points)**
- Information regarding non-standard bicycles such as tandems, recumbent bicycles, tricycles, cargo bicycles, and bicycles with trailers **(2 points)**
- Real-time information on the composition of trains and the location of bicycle spaces (app) **(2 points)**

Appendix L

Adapted Website/App Functionality Indicator

The following criteria were adapted to distinguish between features Amtrak's platform currently offers in preliminary or partial form and the fuller functionality each indicator is intended to measure.

- A tool within the initial route/journey search—before a specific train is selected—that actively filters results to show bike-compatible itineraries. (Does not include a bicycle add-on offered only after a train has already been selected during checkout.) **(2 points)**
- A live count of remaining bicycle spaces visible during the itinerary/route selection stage. **(2 points)**
- Information addressing how non-standard bicycles (tandems, recumbents, tricycles, cargo bikes, bikes with trailers) are handled onboard—including size or weight limits where applicable, boxing or disassembly requirements, or route-specific exceptions with handling instructions. (A notice stating that non-standard bicycles do not fit standard racks, even if size limits are given, does not satisfy this unless accompanied by guidance on how at least some non-standard configurations can be carried.) **(2 points)**
- A single webpage or cohesive section containing complete bicycle-carriage information for the entire network—including which routes offer bike service, which stations along each route offer bicycle carriage, and the bicycle capacity per route—without requiring navigation to separate route-specific pages for complete information. **(2 points)**
- One unified train journey planner in which bicycle reservation is fully integrated with passenger ticket booking, with the system clearly indicating when a leg of a trip does not support bicycle booking, rather than suppressing the bicycle option for the entire itinerary. **(2 points)**

Verification finding: Amtrak's booking platform was tested directly on July 23, 2026. During route/train selection, a per-train "Services" icon indicates bike service exists on a line, but shows no real-time space count; a live count appears only later, on the "Additional Items" page, which combines a full round-trip itinerary into one step and shows the bicycle add-on only if each leg has bike service. On a test round trip (Washington, DC [WAS] → Boston, MA [BOS]) where the outbound leg (*Northeast Regional*) had bike service, and the return leg (*Acela*) did not, no bicycle add-on or space count appeared on the "Additional Items" page at all, and nothing on the page indicated that the return train was the reason. A rider who had not already noticed and checked the per-train "Services" icon during route selection would have no way of knowing that their choice of return train eliminated bicycle booking for the entire trip.

Appendix M

Reservation Requirement Indicator

Unlike the other software indicators in this framework—where a clear “better” configuration exists (lower ticket cost is better, more booking channels are better, more user-friendly websites are better)—reservation requirements present a genuine trade-off rather than a single best practice.

Requiring advance reservations benefits travelers who plan ahead, particularly those organizing multi-day bikepacking trips, group rides, or trips built around specific train connections. A guaranteed reservation system means these travelers can confirm bike space well in advance and build their itinerary around it.

Not requiring reservations, by contrast, benefits spontaneous travelers—the cyclist who decides on a Friday afternoon to take their bike up the coast for the weekend, or who wants to combine a bike trip with an unplanned visit to a city along the route. Reservation-required systems can leave these travelers stranded if bike spaces have been booked out weeks or months earlier.

Because both configurations serve legitimate traveler needs, both earn points, with a modest 2-point preference (6 vs. 4) for the reservation-required model in recognition of the planning predictability it offers—particularly important for the bikepacking and long-distance touring communities represented on the Task Force.

The highest score, however, is reserved for hybrid systems that offer both reserved and non-reserved bike spaces on the same line. Such an arrangement captures the benefits of both approaches: planners can lock in guaranteed space for trips that depend on it, while spontaneous travelers retain the ability to bring their bikes aboard on short notice. Because a hybrid configuration uniquely serves both communities the Task Force represents, it earns 10 points—meaningfully above either single-mode approach.

Reservation Requirement

- Yes & No (i.e., a hybrid system) [Some bike spaces require reservations while others do not] **(10 points)**
- Yes **(6 points)**
- No **(4 points)**
- Not applicable because the line does not have bicycle service(s) offered **(0 points)**

Appendix N

ECF's 2025 Languages Indicator

- **5 points:** 6 or more languages
- **4 points:** 5 languages
- **3 points:** 4 languages
- **2 points:** 3 languages
- **1 point:** 2 languages
- **0 points:** 1 language

Appendix O

Station Staffing Indicator

Scoring Bin for a Line's Percentage of U.S. Stations with Staffing

- **10 points:** 90-100%
- **9 points:** 80-89.99%
- **8 points:** 70-79.99%
- **7 point:** 60-69.99%
- **6 points:** 50-59.99%
- **5 points:** 40-49.99%
- **4 points:** 30-39.99%
- **3 points:** 20-29.99%
- **2 points:** 10-19.99%
- **1 point:** 0.01-9.99%
- **0 points:** 0%/Not Applicable

Appendix P

Station Staffing Indicator Scoring (for Domestic-Only Train Service)

Amtrak Line (and schedule)	Station Jurisdiction	Station Code	Staffed Station? [1= yes, 0 = no]	Total Number of Stations	Number of Staffed Stations	Percent of Line's Stations that are Staffed
<i>Hiawatha</i> (Monday-Friday [North-bound]; linked Amtrak schedule*) [Service No. 329]	Chicago, IL (Union Station)	CHI	1	5	2	40%
	Glenview, IL	GLN	0			
	Sturtevant, WI	SVT	0			
	Milwaukee, WI (General Mitchell Airport Trains)	MKA	0			
	Milwaukee, WI (Downtown)	MKE	1			
Total			2			

Appendix Q

Station Staffing Indicator Scoring (for International Routes)

Amtrak Line (and schedule)	Station Jurisdiction	Station Code	Staffed Station? [1= yes, 0 = no]	Total Number of Stations	Number of Staffed Stations	Percent of Line's Stations that are Staffed
<i>Maple Leaf</i> (Sunday- Thurs; link to Amtrak schedule*) [Service No. 63]	New York, NY (Moynihan Train Hall)	NYP	1	16	11	68.75%
	Yonkers, NY	YNY	0			
	Croton-Harmon, NY	CRT	0			
	Poughkeepsie, NY	POU	0			
	Rhinecliff, NY	RHI	1			
	Hudson, NY	HUD	1			
	Albany-Rensselaer, NY	ALB	1			
	Schenectady, NY	SDY	1			
	Amsterdam, NY	AMS	0			
	Utica, NY	UCA	1			
	Rome, NY	ROM	0			
	Syracuse, NY (Regional Transportation Center)	SYR	1			
	Rochester, NY (Louise M. Slaughter Station)	ROC	1			
	Buffalo, NY (Depew Station)	BUF	1			
	Buffalo, NY (Exchange Street Station)	BFX	1			
	Niagara Falls, NY	NFL	1			
	Niagara Falls, ON	NFS	0			
	Toronto, ON (Union Station)	TWO	1			
Total			12			
			minus 1, equals: 11 US Stations on line are staffed			

Appendix R

Slide from Bodenschatz et al.'s "Shared Micromobility: Research Roundup" Presentation for the North American Bikeshare and Scootershare Association on April 22, 2026

Integrated payments for shared micromobility first/last mile access to public transit

Hope Bodenschatz (PhD student, Transportation Technology and Policy), Kari Watkins, Dillon Fitch-Polse, Susie Pike

April 2026

Background

Motivation and Research Question

Capitol Corridor ridership has not fully recovered post-pandemic, encouraging the agency to adopt new strategies to attract riders to its service. This inspired our research question:

Can providing free micromobility trips to and from transit stations increase ridership?

Existing transit and shared micromobility payment integrations

	Verification of transit usage		
	No verification	Manual verification/geofencing	Verification by transit ticket purchase
Unlock capability or shared payment system/pass (no discount)	LA Metro TAP card Clipper card SMART (Sonoma-Marin) KCATA (Kansas City)		
Accrue transit or local business rewards/credits	Deutsche Bahn RAD+	Palo Alto Bike Love	Seattle Miami-Dade County
Earn day pass or limited number of no-cost rides	WMATA (DC)	SMM trips: RABA/Redding Bikeshare Transit trips: SacRT (Sacramento)	COMET (Columbia, SC)
Automatic discount on qualifying first/last mile ride		RTD (Denver) DART (Dallas)	UC Davis SPIN-Capitol Corridor pilot

Has your company adopted or considered adopting a payment integration for multimodal use of shared micromobility and transit? Tell us about it!

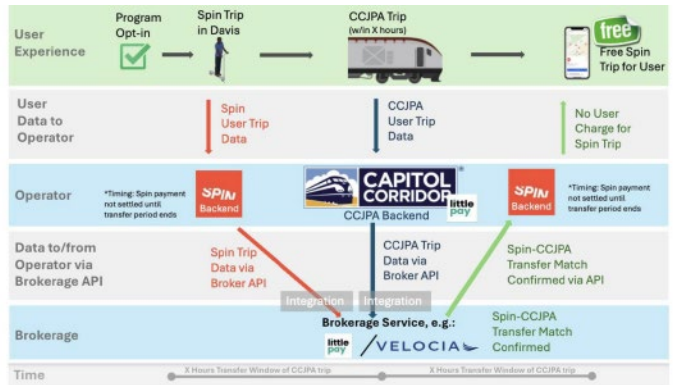
Contact:

Hope Bodenschatz (hebodenschatz@ucdavis.edu), Kari Watkins (kewatkins@ucdavis.edu)

SPIN-Capitol Corridor payment integration and study design

First integration to offer closest to automatic shared micromobility discount for verified transit trip possible

- Daily refunds for verified SPIN trips to the Davis, CA Amtrak station
- Verified purchase of Capitol Corridor ticket



Integration coordination supported by



Source: Colin Hughes

Understand impact of facilitating first/last mile access on public transit use

- Behavioral trial starting Fall 2026

- Subset of study participants receive free qualifying SPIN trips and their Capitol Corridor usage will be compared to control group who do not receive subsidy

Share knowledge about developing shared micromobility-transit payment integrations

Appendix S

Adapted Booking Channels Indicator

Number of Booking Channels

- **10 points:** 5 or more
- **8 points:** 4
- **6 points:** 3
- **4 points:** 2
- **2 points:** 1
- **0 points:** 0/Not Available

Explanation: The booking channels indicator uses a straightforward linear scale rather than the European Cyclists' Federation's original criteria, which awarded five points to operators offering free onboard carriage without a reservation requirement (see [Appendix H](#)). That accommodation was excluded here because the Task Force framework includes a dedicated Reservation Requirement indicator (see [Appendix M](#)) that already evaluates whether reservations are needed and rewards hybrid systems accordingly. Retaining the ECF's 5-point tier would risk scoring the same policy dimension twice, artificially inflating scores for operators that happen to allow walk-on bicycle access. The simplified scale instead keeps this indicator focused exclusively on the number of available booking channels.

Appendix T

ECF's Booking Channel Indicator Scoring (2025)

Number of Booking Channels

- **10 points:** 5 or more
- **8 points:** 4
- **6 points:** 3
- **5 points:** Carriage is free & does not require a reservation
- **4 points:** 2
- **2 points:** 1
- **0 points:** 0 booking channels/Not Available

Appendix U

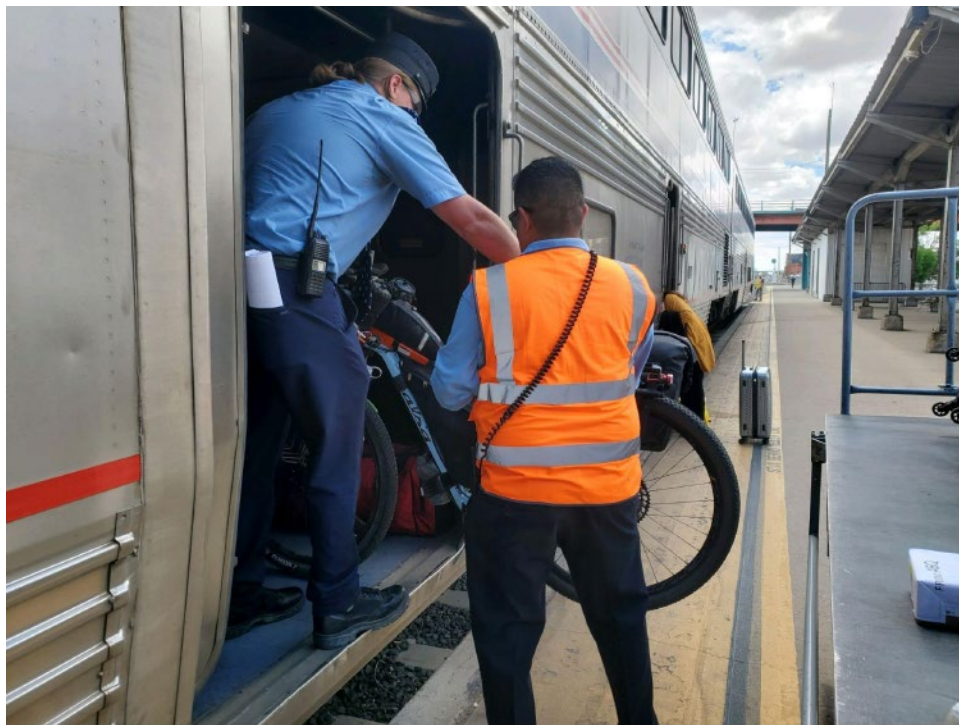
Scoring Breakdown Across All Amtrak Lines

Notes: N/A = Not Applicable; † = See "A Note on the Capitol Corridor" ([Appendix UU](#))

Amtrak Line	Bike Spaces	Bicycle Ticket Cost	Reservation Requirement	Booking Channels	Station Staffing	Bonus/ Minus	Web-site	Final Score
<i>Acela</i>	0	N/A	N/A	N/A	10		0	10
<i>Adirondack</i>	0	N/A	N/A	N/A	5		0	5
<i>Auto Train</i>	0	N/A	N/A	N/A	10		0	10
<i>Berkshire Flyer</i>	0	N/A	N/A	N/A	7		0	7
<i>Blue Water</i>	50	2	6	10	2	2	0	72
<i>Borealis</i>	0	N/A	N/A	N/A	4		0	4
<i>California Zephyr</i>	30	0	6	10	4		0	50
<i>Capitol Corridor</i> [†]	15	10	4	10	5	2	0	46
<i>Cardinal</i>	30	0	6	10	5		0	51
<i>Carl Sandburg</i>	20	2	6	10	4		0	42
<i>Carolinian</i> (\$0 bike ticket)	20	10	6	10	8		0	54
<i>Carolinian</i> (\$20 bike ticket)	20	0	6	10	8		0	44
<i>Cascades</i>	50	10	6	10	7	4	0	87
<i>City of New Orleans</i>	10	0	6	10	5		0	31
<i>Coast Starlight</i> (\$0 bike ticket)	30	10	6	10	8		0	64
<i>Coast Starlight</i> (\$5 bike ticket)	30	5	6	10	8		0	59
<i>Coast Starlight</i> (\$20 bike ticket)	30	0	6	10	8		0	54
<i>Crescent</i>	30	0	6	10	6		0	52
<i>Downeaster</i>	40	5	6	10	10	-2	0	69
<i>Empire Builder</i>	30	0	6	10	5	-2	0	49
<i>Empire Service</i>	20	0	6	10	7		0	43
<i>Ethan Allen Express</i>	20	0	6	10	5		0	41
<i>Floridian</i> (previously <i>Silver Star</i> ; <i>Capitol Limited</i>)	10	0	6	10	7		0	33
<i>Gold Runner</i> (formerly <i>San Joaquins</i>)	50	10	4	10	6	6	0	86
<i>Hartford Line</i>	5	2	6	10	4		0	27
<i>Heartland Flyer</i>	0	N/A	N/A	N/A	2		0	2
<i>Hiawatha</i>	50	5	6	10	5	2	0	78
<i>Illini</i>	20	2	6	10	4		0	42
<i>Illinois Zephyr</i>	20	2	6	10	4		0	42
<i>Keystone Service</i>	10	0	6	10	5		0	31
<i>Lake Shore Limited</i>	30	0	6	10	6		0	52
<i>Lincoln Service</i>	20	2	6	10	6		0	44
<i>Maple Leaf</i>	20	0	6	10	7		0	43
<i>Mardi Gras</i>	0	N/A	N/A	N/A	2		0	2
<i>Missouri River Runner</i>	20	2	6	10	3		0	41
<i>Northeast Regional</i>	20	0	6	10	9		0	45
<i>Pacific Surfliner</i>	35	10	6	10	4	10	0	75
<i>Palmetto</i>	30	0	6	10	9		0	55
<i>Pennsylvanian</i>	30	0	6	10	6		0	52
<i>Pere Marquette</i>	50	2	6	10	3	2	0	73
<i>Piedmont</i>	25	10	6	10	6	2	0	59
<i>Saluki</i>	20	2	6	10	3		0	41
<i>Silver Meteor</i>	30	0	6	10	8		0	54
<i>Southwest Chief</i>	30	0	6	10	5		0	51
<i>Sunset Limited</i>	30	2	6	10	4		0	52
<i>Texas Eagle</i>	10	0	6	10	5		0	31
<i>Valley Flyer</i>	30	2	6	10	3		0	51
<i>Vermont</i>	30	0	6	10	5		0	51
<i>Wolverine</i>	50	2	6	10	4	2	0	74

Appendix V

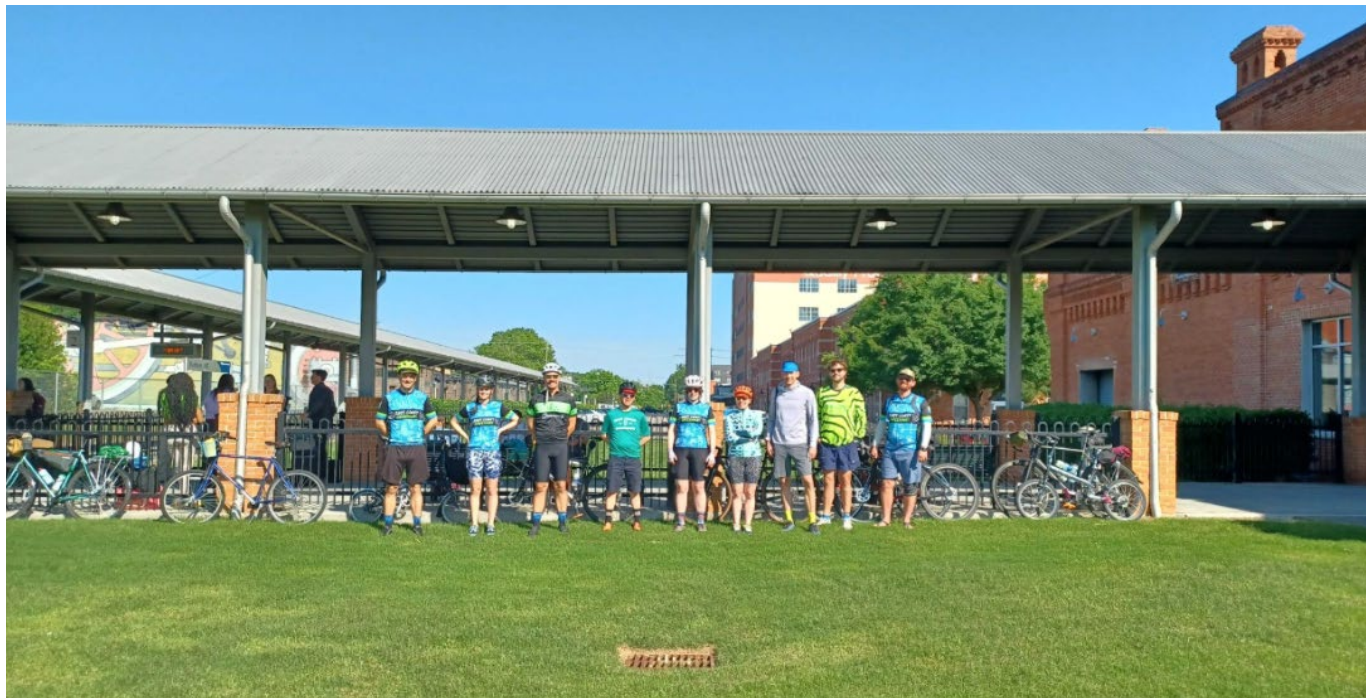
From Bikepacking Roots: Using Amtrak to Facilitate a Ride on the Pony Express Route



(Photos: Jan Bennett)

Appendix W

From East Coast Greenway Alliance: East Coast Greenway Alliance staff at the Durham, NC, Amtrak station (DNC) waiting to board the Carolinian bound for Raleigh to start the “Cross Triangle Ride”



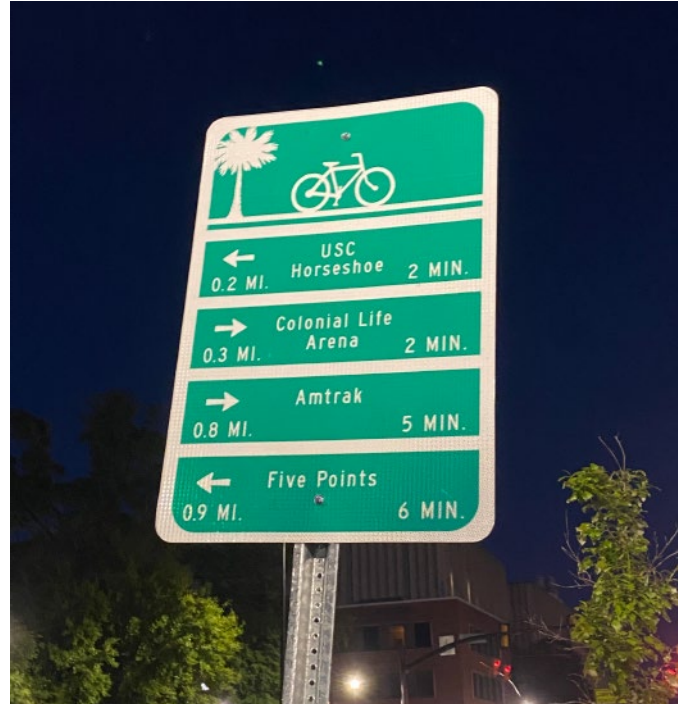
Appendix X

From East Coast Greenway Alliance: Loading Bikes at the Durham, North Carolina Amtrak Station (DNC)



Appendix Y

From Cola Town Bike Collective: Announcing Bicycle Wayfinding Signs Downtown and to Columbia, South Carolina's Amtrak Station (CLB)



Appendix AA

Amtrak Task Force 2024 Letter to Amtrak Chief Executive Stephen Gardner (March 6, 2024)



*We're leading the movement to build a bicycle-friendly America
for everyone*

1612 K STREET NW, SUITE 1102, WASHINGTON, DC 20006
| phone 202-822-1333 | fax 202-822-1334 |
WWW.BIKELEAGUE.ORG

March 6, 2024

Mr. Stephen Gardner
Chief Executive Officer
Amtrak
1 Mass. Ave. NW
Washington, DC 20001

Dear Mr. Gardner,

The Amtrak Bike Task Force, a coalition of local, state, and national cycling and tourism organizations, is writing to express our sincere desire to work together to improve mobility for Amtrak passengers. This is an exciting time for the Task Force as we are seeing more and more Amtrak customers bringing their bikes on the train. There was a 10.1% increase in bikes carried from FY22 to FY23 and an 8.7% increase in revenues. Additionally, in FY23 bikes contributed \$718,403.57 out of \$3,519,058 in total carry-on revenue, 20.4 percent. In 2024 we are interested in working together to improve the ease and ability for passengers to travel with bikes, and to improve options for first and last mile travel to and from the train including access to micro-mobility. **We believe connecting Amtrak and active transportation is a critical element of an overall multi-modal transportation system, which we advocate for in Congress and around the country.**

The Task Force has partnered with Amtrak for over a decade, and we commend Amtrak for recognizing the importance of accommodating cyclists and promoting multi-modal transportation solutions. The efforts made thus far, including improving policy transparency during bookings and increasing bike capacity on select trains and lines, have supported the broader goals of mobility for Amtrak passengers for tourism and travel.

As advocates for a bike-friendly transportation system, we are pleased to see the progress Amtrak has made to improve the experience for bike users and we believe there is still opportunity to address barriers to access for cyclists trying to use Amtrak. We encourage Amtrak to prioritize and invest in initiatives aimed at enhancing the experience of customers with bikes.

Appendix AA (continued)

Amtrak Task Force 2024 Letter to Amtrak Chief Executive Stephen Gardner (March 6, 2024)

Our recommendations for future improvements include:

- 1) Ensure that the new Airo trains will include more and better bicycle storage on existing routes, and increase bicycle storage on new routes.
- 2) Making it easier for passengers to travel by bike by:
 - Not requiring customers to remove a bike wheel to store the bike.
 - Allowing more than one bike per car so travelers can sit together in the same car with their bikes.
 - Ensuring bike hooks are at least four inches wide to fit standard mountain bike tires.
 - Ensuring new bike racks include the appropriate materials and straps to minimize scratching and swaying, as illustrated in the 2024 Streetsblog post.
<https://sf.streetsblog.org/2024/02/01/review-amtrak-california-passengers-are-starving-for-new-trains>
- 3) Simplify customer ticketing experience by limiting the number of times customers have to pay for bike transport to once, even when connecting. It is also worth noting, that in some regions, Amtrak customers are paying almost as much or more for bike service when they're connecting, as they are for their seat.

These improvements enhance a sustainable multi-modal transportation ecosystem, helps address first/last mile challenges for some customers and make Amtrak trips more accessible to cyclists. We appreciate the investments and partnership that we have had with Amtrak. We look forward to continuing to work with you to ensure a strong Amtrak network that has the resources to provide better mobility choices for customers, including those with bicycles.

Thank you for the dedicated work of your staff, Derrick James and Mariah Morales, who have helped us understand the challenges and opportunities within Amtrak to improve bike service. We look forward to your continued partnership and to the exciting future ahead! Please reach out to the Amtrak Bike Task Force Coordinator Caron Whitaker at 202-215-3908 or, via email at Caron@bikeleague.org with any questions.

Thank you,

Amtrak Bike Task Force.



Caron Whitaker
Coordinator, Amtrak Bike Task Force

Cc: Mariah Morales, Amtrak
Derrick James, Amtrak

Appendix BB

Amtrak Chief Executive Stephen Gardner's Response to Amtrak Task Force Letter (May 26, 2024)

AMTRAK
1 Massachusetts Avenue, NW, Washington, DC 20001
Email stephen.gardner@amtrak.com Tel 202.906.3963

Stephen J. Gardner
Chief Executive Officer



May 24, 2024

Ms. Caron Whitaker
The League of American Bicyclists
1612 K Street, NW, Suite 1102
Washington, DC 20001

Dear Ms. Whitaker:

Thank you for your March 6 letter regarding the recommendations of the Amtrak Bike Task Force for improving the experience of Amtrak customers who travel with bikes.

Let me begin by saying how much we at Amtrak appreciate the contributions the members of the Task Force have made to our efforts to make trains more accessible to passengers bringing bikes. The Task Force has played a major role in what Amtrak and the bike community have accomplished over the past few years. Specifically:

- The implementation of carry-on bike service on the Northeast Corridor and many state-supported routes that previously lacked it has made it possible for the majority of our passengers to travel with their bikes in a relatively seamless manner, without the impediments and limitations of having to box their bikes and being able to travel only on routes and between stations that offered checked baggage service.
- The challenges of accommodating bikes on legacy equipment designed a half century ago without provision for bike carriage and of meeting the growing demand for travel with bikes have been ameliorated by equipment modifications and by prioritizing assignment of Baggage Cars to long distance routes with high demand for bike space.
- The input of the Amtrak Bike Task Force and other members of the biking community has helped us improve transport of bikes and to better communicate, through our website and other means, with our customers who are traveling with bikes. This input has also made a major contribution to the design of our new equipment that will make it easier to travel with bikes and increase bike capacity on our trains.

As you note in your letter, these efforts produced a more than 10% increase in the number of bikes transported on Amtrak trains last year and a somewhat smaller increase in bike revenue. More importantly, every bike we carried was accompanied by an Amtrak passenger making a multi-modal trip that, in terms of energy use, emissions and impact on road congestion, was even more sustainable than travel by train alone.

Appendix BB (continued)

Amtrak Chief Executive Stephen Gardner's Response to Amtrak Task Force Letter (May 26, 2024)



*Ms. Caron Whitaker
May 24, 2024
Page 2*

With regard to the specific recommendations for future improvements the Bike Task Force has made:

1. *Ensure that the new Airo trains will include more and better bicycle storage on existing routes and increase bicycle storage on new routes.*

Each Airo coach car will have one baggage/bicycle tower that will be able to accommodate two bicycles when used for bike transport. Some Airo trainsets will include a baggage compartment with additional spaces that can be used for bike storage (either as checked baggage or self-service).

2. *Make it easier for passengers to travel by bike by:*

- a. *Not requiring customers to remove a bike wheel to store the bike.*

Removal of a bike wheel on routes that utilize legacy equipment is necessary because of the limited space in the areas used for bike storage. The baggage/bicycle towers on the Venture trainsets our state partners are acquiring for Midwest and California routes and on the new Amtrak Airo trainsets will have sufficient room to accommodate bikes without removal of wheels.

- b. *Allowing more than one bike per car so travelers can sit together in the same car with their bikes.*

Current limits on the number of bikes are based upon the space available for bike storage in legacy equipment. The baggage/bicycle towers that will be located in each Coach will have room for three bicycles on the Venture trainsets and two bikes on the Amtrak Airos. While the need to accommodate carry-on luggage will have to be taken into account in determining how many towers on each train will be reserved for bicycles, multiple passengers with bikes may be able to travel in the same car and the new towers will increase bike capacity and provide greater flexibility to match it to demand.

- c. *Ensuring bike hooks are at least four inches wide to fit standard mountain bike tires.*

Based on stakeholder feedback received during mock-up inspections, we have increased the size of the bike hooks on the Amtrak Airos from two inches to three inches wide, the largest size that will fit within the configuration of the baggage/

Appendix BB (continued)

Amtrak Chief Executive Stephen Gardner's Response to Amtrak Task Force Letter (May 26, 2024)



Ms. Caron Whitaker
May 24, 2024
Page 3

bicycle towers. The three-inch hooks will be able to accommodate most mountain bikes other than those with oversized “fat tires.”

- d. *Ensuring new bike racks include the appropriate materials and straps to minimize scratching and swaying, as illustrated in the 2024 Streetsblog post.*

Other than the report in the Streetsblog post, we are not aware of any problems with bike securement or bikes falling off racks on the Venture cars that our state partners are acquiring for Midwestern and California state-supported routes. We will continue to monitor feedback from customers who travel with bikes on the new Venture cars. Please note that any improvements to the state-owned equipment will need to be directed and funded by the owning states.

3. *Simplify customer ticketing experience by limiting the number of times customers have to pay for bike transport to once, even when connecting.*

Amtrak’s bike charges for most trips compare favorably to the cost of transporting a bike on a plane or bus or shipping it to and from a destination. Because of the way Amtrak’s Arrow reservations system is configured, it would not be feasible to charge a single price for bicycles on a multi-train itinerary.

In the near term, the most important things Amtrak can do to enable more travelers with bikes to use our trains are increasing our active equipment fleet, augmenting bike capacity on existing equipment where possible, and adding new routes and additional trains on existing routes. A number of initiatives currently underway will increase our capacity to accommodate bikes.

- During Fiscal Year 2024, we are restoring 55 cars to our active equipment fleet that have been out of service because they required major repairs or federally-mandated overhauls that were delayed due to the COVID-19 pandemic. These cars include six Viewliner Baggage cars, whose return to service will allow us to operate Baggage cars with more spaces for bikes on the Chicago-to-Los Angeles *Southwest Chief*, and two Superliner Coach-Baggage cars and 18 Horizon Coaches that will have spaces for bikes.
- We are modifying Superliner Coach-Baggage cars so that all of them will have the same number of both standalone bike and combination bike-luggage racks. Having a uniform fleet of cars with significant capacity for bikes will allow us to carry more bikes on routes to which these cars are assigned.
- The recent shift to fixed forward/backwards seating on our *Northeast Regional* trains, which reduces turnaround times at terminals, has allowed us to add eight new weekday

Appendix BB (continued)

Amtrak Chief Executive Stephen Gardner's Response to Amtrak Task Force Letter (May 26, 2024)



Ms. Caron Whitaker

May 24, 2024

Page 4

and four new Sunday frequencies along the Northeast Corridor that will provide additional capacity for bikes as well as passengers.

- We will be adding new state-supported services between Chicago and St. Paul and New Orleans and Mobile that will accommodate bikes.

Your letter concludes with the statement that there is “an exciting future ahead!” I could not agree more – and that is true for Amtrak and all of our passengers, particularly those who travel with bikes. The unprecedented funding for capital investments the Infrastructure Investment and Jobs Act (IIJA) provides is allowing Amtrak to order long-overdue replacements for our legacy equipment fleets and to pursue significant expansion of service in conjunction our federal and state partners. Offering more service and carrying more passengers on equipment designed for bike transport will allow us to carry many more passengers – and bikes – on our trains as we strive to achieve our goal of doubling ridership by 2040.

Looking ahead, the two factors that will determine whether we can continue – and accelerate – the progress we have made in accommodating bicycles are the level of annual federal appropriations we receive and continued access, for us and our state partners, to significant, multi-year, funding after the IIJA’s advance appropriations end in 2026. Our annual appropriations provide nearly all of the funding for near-term initiatives to improve bike service such as those I have described above. Continuation of the multi-year funding for major capital investments the IIJA provides is essential to enable Amtrak to replace our remaining legacy equipment with modern, bike-friendly, passenger railcars and to advance plans to grow our service.

Thank you for all that you do to support Amtrak. I encourage you to continue to share your thoughts and recommendations with my Amtrak colleagues who work with the Bike Task Force.

Sincerely,

A handwritten signature in blue ink, appearing to read "Stephen J. Gardner".

Stephen J. Gardner
Chief Executive Officer

Appendix CC

Unstaffed Amtrak Stations Offering Bicycle Service(s)¹¹⁵

To date, Amtrak has expanded bicycle service to the following routes and stations, regardless of station staffing status:

- Prince, WV (**PRC**) on the *Cardinal*
- Fraser-Winter Park, CO (**WPK**) on the *California Zephyr*
- Stanwood, WA (**STW**), Tukwila, WA (**TUK**), and Oregon City, OR (**ORC**) on the *Cascades*
- Winona, MN (**WIN**) and West Glacier, MT (**WGL**) on the *Empire Builder*
- High Point, NC (**HPT**) on the *Crescent*
- All stations between Charlotte and Raleigh on the *Carolinian*
 - Cary, NC (**CYN**)
 - Durham, NC (**DNC**)
 - Burlington, NC (**BNC**)
 - Greensboro, NC (**GRO**)
 - High Point, NC (**HPT**)
 - Salisbury, NC (**SAL**)
 - Kannapolis, NC (**KAN**)
- All unstaffed stations on the *Pere Marquette*
 - St. Joseph-Benton Harbor, MI (**SJM**)
 - Bangor, MI (**BAM**)
 - Holland, MI (**HOM**)
 - Grand Rapids, MI (**GRR**)

¹¹⁵ Amtrak. (n.d.-b). "Answers to Your Questions About Bikes Onboard." <https://www.amtrak.com/bike-faqs>

Appendix DD

Bonus/Minus Indicator Scoring by Line

Amtrak Line	Bonus Points	Minus Points	Net Value
<i>Blue Water</i>	Plus 2 (Over 10 bicycle spaces)		Plus 2
<i>Capitol Corridor</i>	Plus 2 (Accepts tires 2+ in. wide)		Plus 2
<i>Cascades</i>	Plus 2 ("Where to Ride" guide) Plus 2 (Carry-On & Trainside Checked)		Plus 4
<i>Downeaster</i>		Minus 2 (Front wheel removal required)	Minus 2
<i>Empire Builder</i>		Minus 2 (Part of route requires bike to be stored in box)	Minus 2
<i>Gold Runner</i> (formerly <i>San Joaquins</i>)	Plus 2 (Over 10 bicycle spaces) Plus 2 (Accepts tires 2+ in. wide) Plus 2 (Carry-On & Trainside Checked)		Plus 6
<i>Hiawatha</i>	Plus 2 (Over 10 bicycle spaces)		Plus 2
<i>Pacific Surfliner</i>	Plus 2 (Accepts tandem bikes) Plus 2 ("Where to Ride" guide) Plus 2 (Accepts tires 2+ in. wide) Plus 2 (Accepts tires up to 4 in. wide) Plus 2 (Carry-On & Trainside Checked)		Plus 10
<i>Pere Marquette</i>	Plus 2 (Over 10 bicycle spaces)		Plus 2
<i>Piedmont</i>	Plus 2 (Carry-On & Trainside Checked)		Plus 2
<i>Wolverine</i>	Plus 2 (Over 10 bicycle spaces)		Plus 2

Appendix EE

Two-Wheeled Tandem on *Pacific Surfliner*¹¹⁶



¹¹⁶ Amtrak *Pacific Surfliner*. (n.d.). "Bring Your Bike: Add a Free Bike Reservation." <https://www.pacificsurfliner.com/onboard/bikes/>

Appendix FF

Scoring Bin Distribution for Lines with Bike Services Offered

<i>Distribution by Scoring Bin</i>		
Scoring Bin	Count	% of Lines / Visual
Excellent (80–100)	2	5.1% 
Good (60–79)	6	15.4% 
Moderate (40–59)	26	66.7% 
Poor (20–39)	5	12.8% 
Very Poor (0–19)	0	0.0%
Total	39	100.0%

Appendix GG

Scoring Bin Distribution for All Lines (Full Network)

<i>Distribution by Scoring Bin</i>		
Scoring Bin	Count	% of Lines / Visual
Excellent (80–100)	2	4.3% 
Good (60–79)	6	13.0% 
Moderate (40–59)	26	56.5% 
Poor (20–39)	5	10.9% 
Very Poor (0–19)	7	15.2% 
Total	46	100.0%

Appendix HH

Highest Scoring Lines Among Those with Bicycle Service(s) Offered

Rank	Amtrak Line	Score
1	<i>Cascades</i>	87
2	<i>Gold Runner</i> (formerly <i>San Joaquins</i>)	86
3	<i>Hiawatha</i>	78
4	<i>Pacific Surfliner</i>	75
5	<i>Wolverine</i>	74

Lowest Scoring Lines Among Those with Bicycle Service(s) Offered

Rank	Amtrak Line	Score
1	<i>Hartford</i>	27
2	<i>City of New Orleans</i>	31
3	<i>Keystone Service</i>	31
4	<i>Texas Eagle</i>	31
5	<i>Floridian</i>	33

Appendix II

Highest Scores Across All Lines (Full Network)

Rank	Amtrak Line	Score
1	<i>Cascades</i>	87
2	<i>Gold Runner</i> (formerly <i>San Joaquins</i>)	86
3	<i>Hiawatha</i>	78
4	<i>Pacific Surfliner</i>	75
5	<i>Wolverine</i>	74

Lowest Scores Across All Lines (Full Network)

Rank	Amtrak Line	Score
1	<i>Heartland Flyer</i>	2
2	<i>Mardi Gras</i>	2
3	<i>Borealis</i>	4
4	<i>Adirondack</i>	5
5	<i>Berkshire Flyer</i>	7

Appendix JJ

Scoring Statistics by Bicycle Service Type

<i>Variation by Service Type Offered</i>					
Service Type	Count	Mean	Median	Min	Max
Carry-on only	20	48.60	43.5	27	78
Trainside Checked only	15	49.67	52	31	73
Both	4	76.75	80.5	59	87
None (no bike service)	7	5.71	5	2	10
All bike-service lines	39	51.90	51	27	87
Mean gap (service – no service)		46.18			

Appendix KK

Scoring Variation by Bike Service Availability

<i>Variation by Bike-Service Availability</i>					
<i>Bike Service Offered</i>	<i>Number of Lines</i>	<i>Mean</i>	<i>Median</i>	<i>Min</i>	<i>Max</i>
Yes	39	51.90	51	27	87
No	7	5.71	5	2	10
Mean gap (Yes – No)		46.18			

Appendix LL

Descriptive Statistics for Amtrak Lines with Bike Services

Central Tendency & Spread		
Statistic	Value	Interpretation
Count	39	Number of lines in this analysis
Mean (average)	51.90	Arithmetic average score
Median	51	Middle value when scores are ranked
Mode	51	Most frequently occurring score
Standard deviation	15.06	Typical spread around the mean
Minimum	27	Lowest score
Maximum	87	Highest score
Range	60	Max minus min

Appendix MM

Descriptive Statistics for All Amtrak Lines

Central Tendency & Spread		
Statistic	Value	Interpretation
Count	46	Number of lines in this analysis
Mean (average)	44.87	Arithmetic average score
Median	47.5	Middle value when scores are ranked
Mode	52	Most frequently occurring score
Standard deviation (sample)	21.78	Typical spread around the mean
Minimum	2	Lowest score
Maximum	87	Highest score
Range	85	Max minus min

Appendix NN

Amtrak State-Supported Lines¹¹⁷

AMTRAK'S STATE SUPPORTED ROUTES

REGION	ROUTE	CITIES SERVED	FUNDING PARTNER(S)
NORTHEAST	The Downeaster	Boston–Portland–Brunswick	Northern New England Passenger Rail Authority (NNEPRA)
	New Haven–Springfield	New Haven–Springfield	Connecticut, Massachusetts
	Vermont	Washington–St. Albans, VT	Vermont, Connecticut, Massachusetts
	Empire Service	New York–Albany–Niagara Falls	New York State
	Maple Leaf	New York–Toronto	New York State
	Adirondack	New York–Montreal	New York State
	Ethan Allen Express	New York–Rutland, VT	Vermont, New York State
	Keystone Service	New York–Philadelphia–Harrisburg	Pennsylvania
	Pennsylvanian	New York–Philadelphia–Pittsburgh	Pennsylvania
SOUTH	Washington–Roanoke	Boston–Roanoke	Virginia
	Washington–Newport News	Boston–Newport News	Virginia
	Washington–Norfolk	Boston–Norfolk	Virginia
	Washington–Richmond	Boston–Richmond	Virginia
	Carolinian	New York–Charlotte	North Carolina
	Piedmont	Charlotte–Raleigh	North Carolina
	Heartland Flyer	Oklahoma City–Fort Worth	Oklahoma, Texas
CENTRAL	Lincoln Service	Chicago–St. Louis	Illinois
	Illini / Saluki	Chicago–Carbondale	Illinois
	Illinois Zephyr / Carl Sandburg	Chicago–Quincy	Illinois
	Hiawatha	Chicago–Milwaukee	Wisconsin, Illinois
	Wolverines	Chicago–Detroit	Michigan
	Blue Water	Chicago–Port Huron	Michigan
	Pere Marquette	Chicago–Grand Rapids	Michigan
	Missouri River Runner	St. Louis–Kansas City	Missouri
WEST	Pacific Surfliner	San Diego–Los Angeles–San Luis Obispo	Los Angeles–San Diego–San Luis Obispo (LOSSAN) Rail Corridor Agency
	San Joaquins	Oakland/Sacramento–Bakersfield	San Joaquin Joint Powers Authority (SJJPA)
	Capitol Corridor	San Jose–Oakland–Sacramento–Auburn	Capitol Corridor Joint Powers Authority (CCJPA)
	California-owned equipment	Various	California Department of Transportation
	Cascades	Vancouver, BC–Seattle–Portland–Eugene	Washington State, Oregon

117 Amtrak. (2020). "Amtrak Five-Year Service Line Plans: Fiscal Years 2020–2025 (Base + Five-Year Strategic Plan)" (pp. 1–156). <https://www.amtrak.com/content/dam/projects/dotcom/english/public/documents/corporate/businessplanning/Amtrak-Service-Line-Plans-FY21-25.pdf>

Appendix OO

Amtrak Long-Distance Lines¹¹⁸

Long Distance Service Summary

LDSL routes provide three classes of passenger service: Coach, Business, and Sleeper. **Coach class**, which is available on all trains, offers reclining seats and access to power outlets. **Business class** is available on four LDSL routes (*Cardinal*, *Coast Starlight*, *Lake Shore Limited*, *Palmetto*) providing additional amenities such as a dedicated car, extra legroom, access to lounges in select stations and complimentary non-alcoholic beverages. **Sleeper class** is available on all LDSL routes except the *Palmetto*. Sleeper passengers enjoy the privacy of their own room (many with a private restroom and shower), prepaid meals, turndown service, and access to lounges in select stations.

LONG DISTANCE SERVICE SUMMARY

Train Name	City Pairs	Frequency
Auto Train	Lorton, VA – Sanford, FL	Daily
California Zephyr	Chicago, IL – Oakland, CA	Daily
Capitol Limited	Chicago, IL – Washington, DC	Daily
Cardinal	Chicago, IL – New York, NY	3x/week
City of New Orleans	Chicago, IL – New Orleans, LA	Daily
Coast Starlight	Los Angeles, CA – Seattle, WA	Daily
Crescent	New York, NY – New Orleans, LA	Daily
Empire Builder	Chicago, IL – Seattle, WA /Portland, OR	Daily
Lake Shore Limited	Chicago, IL – New York, NY/Boston, MA	Daily
Palmetto	New York– Savannah, GA	Daily
Silver Meteor	New York– Miami, FL	Daily
Silver Star	New York, NY – Tampa/Miami, FL	Daily
Southwest Chief	Chicago, IL – Los Angeles, CA	Daily
Sunset Limited	Los Angeles, CA – New Orleans, LA	3x/week
Texas Eagle	Chicago, IL – San Antonio, TX	Daily
	Chicago, IL – Los Angeles, CA	3x/week

ABOUT LONG DISTANCE CUSTOMERS

- Coach class represents 82% of trips.
- Sleeper class represents 15% of trips and 38% of ticket revenue.
- Business class represents 3% of trips.
- Customers are 61% female and 39% male.
- 28% of adult customers are 65 or older.
- 64% travel round-trip.
- 49% of customers are employed and 32% are retired; college students, homemakers and persons who are not employed account for most of the remainder.
- Traveling purpose: 8% business; 60% visit family or friends/ personal or family business; 28% vacation/leisure.
- Average sleeper trip length is 990 miles; average coach trip is less than half as long at 457 miles.

118 Amtrak. (2020). "Amtrak Five-Year Service Line Plans: Fiscal Years 2020-2025 (Base + Five-Year Strategic Plan) (pp.1-156)." <https://www.amtrak.com/content/dam/projects/dotcom/english/public/documents/corporate/businessplanning/Amtrak-Service-Line-Plans-FY21-25.pdf>

Appendix PP

Screenshot of Amtrak's *Crescent* Line Webpage¹¹⁹



BOOK

TRAIN STATUS

MY TRIP

PLAN

SCHEDULES

DEALS

Guest Rewards

English

Need Help?

Crescent

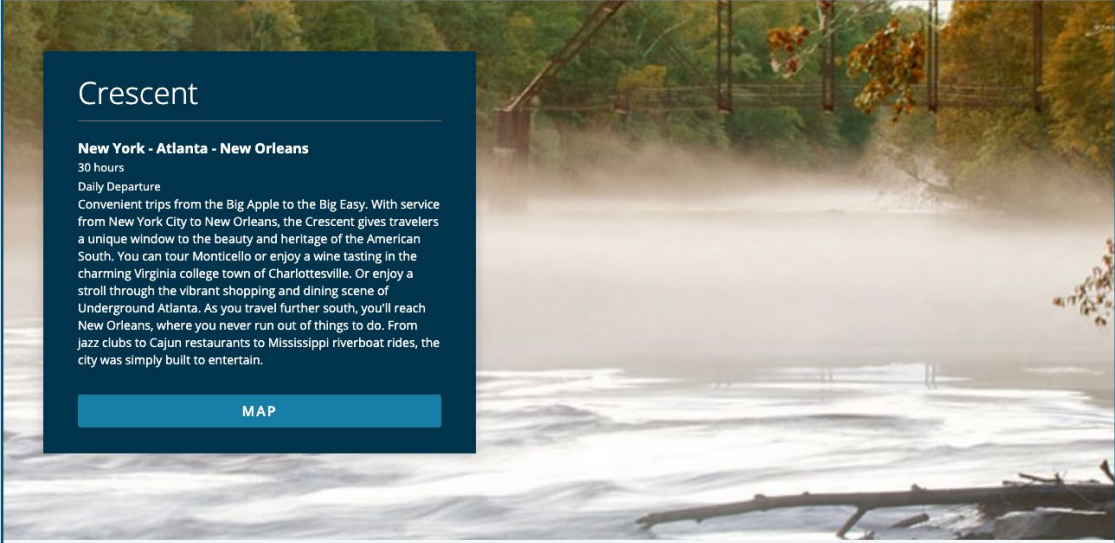
New York - Atlanta - New Orleans

30 hours

Daily Departure

Convenient trips from the Big Apple to the Big Easy. With service from New York City to New Orleans, the Crescent gives travelers a unique window to the beauty and heritage of the American South. You can tour Monticello or enjoy a wine tasting in the charming Virginia college town of Charlottesville. Or enjoy a stroll through the vibrant shopping and dining scene of Underground Atlanta. As you travel further south, you'll reach New Orleans, where you never run out of things to do. From jazz clubs to Cajun restaurants to Mississippi riverboat rides, the city was simply built to entertain.

MAP



Features & Amenities

 Amenities

 Accommodations

 Dining

 Pets

 Local Guides

 Amtrak Connection

- [Checked Baggage Service](#)
- [Wi-Fi Onboard](#)

Amenities vary by train.

Route Highlights

Greenville, South Carolina

Discover the city consistently named one of "America's Best Downtowns." Traverse the dramatic curved suspension bridge over the Reedy or set off on bike or Segway to explore the GHS Swamp Rabbit Trail.

Enjoy a performance at the Peace Center or visit museums boasting masterpieces from Rubens and Wyeth. Savor sushi, soul food and everything in between.



Greenville

Atlanta

¹¹⁹ Amtrak. (n.d.-e). "Crescent." <https://www.amtrak.com/crescent-train>

BICYCLE-FRIENDLY TRAINS: WHERE AMTRAK STANDS ON BICYCLE ACCESS—AND WHAT COMES NEXT · THE LEAGUE OF AMERICAN BICYCLISTS · BIKELEAGUE.ORG

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Appendix QQ

Scoring Bins for Amtrak Lines

Score Range	Scoring Bin
0-19 points	Very Poor
20-39 points	Poor
40-59 points	Moderate
60-79 points	Good
80-100 points	Excellent

Appendix RR

All Amtrak Lines by Bicycle Service(s) Offered

Amtrak Line	Bicycle Service(s) Offered
<i>Acela</i>	None
<i>Adirondack</i>	None
<i>Auto Train</i>	None (although bikes can be attached to a rear-mounted rack on your vehicle at no additional cost)
<i>Berkshire Flyer</i>	None
<i>Blue Water</i>	Carry-on
<i>Borealis</i>	None
<i>California Zephyr</i>	Trainside Checked
<i>Capitol Corridor</i>	Carry-on
<i>Cardinal</i>	Trainside Checked
<i>Carl Sandburg</i>	Carry-on
<i>Carolinian</i>	Carry-on
<i>Cascades</i>	Carry-On & Trainside Checked
<i>City of New Orleans</i>	Trainside Checked
<i>Coast Starlight</i>	Trainside Checked
<i>Crescent</i>	Trainside Checked
<i>Downeaster</i>	Carry-on
<i>Empire Builder</i>	Trainside Checked
<i>Empire Service</i>	Carry-on
<i>Ethan Allen Express</i>	Carry-on
<i>Floridian</i>	Trainside Checked
<i>Gold Runner (formerly San Joaquins)</i>	Carry-on & Trainside Checked
<i>Hartford Line</i>	Carry-on
<i>Heartland Flyer</i>	None
<i>Hiawatha</i>	Carry-on
<i>Illini</i>	Carry-on
<i>Illinois Zephyr</i>	Carry-on
<i>Keystone Service</i>	Carry-on
<i>Lake Shore Limited</i>	Trainside Checked
<i>Lincoln Service</i>	Carry-on
<i>Maple Leaf</i>	Carry-on
<i>Mardi Gras</i>	None
<i>Missouri River Runner</i>	Carry-on
<i>Northeast Regional</i>	Carry-on
<i>Pacific Surfliner</i>	Carry-on & Trainside Checked
<i>Palmetto</i>	Trainside Checked
<i>Pennsylvanian</i>	Trainside Checked
<i>Pere Marquette</i>	Trainside Checked
<i>Piedmont</i>	Carry-on & Trainside Checked
<i>Saluki</i>	Carry-on
<i>Silver Meteor</i>	Trainside Checked
<i>Southwest Chief</i>	Trainside Checked
<i>Sunset Limited</i>	Trainside Checked
<i>Texas Eagle</i>	Trainside Checked
<i>Valley Flyer</i>	Carry-on
<i>Vermont</i>	Carry-on
<i>Wolverine</i>	Carry-on

Appendix SS

Amtrak Bike Task Force's Letter to Amtrak President Roger Harris (July 22, 2026)



**We're leading the movement to build a bicycle-friendly America
for everyone**

1612 K STREET NW, SUITE 1102, WASHINGTON, DC 20006
| phone 202-822-1333 | fax 202-822-1334 |
WWW.BIKELEAGUE.ORG

July 22, 2026

Mr. Roger Harris
President, Amtrak
1 Massachusetts Ave. NW
Washington, DC 20001

Dear Mr. Harris,

On behalf of the Amtrak Bicycle Task Force — a coalition of local, state, and national bicycling and tourism organizations — I want to begin by thanking you and your team for Amtrak's continued partnership on bicycle access. Many of the organizations in our coalition are also among Amtrak's most consistent advocates on Capitol Hill, where we make the case for robust federal investment in passenger rail and multimodal transportation. We see a strong, well-funded Amtrak and an Amtrak that is welcoming to bicyclists as the same goal, and we are grateful for the open dialogue your staff has maintained with us as we pursue it together.

That dialogue has produced real results. When the Task Force last wrote to Amtrak leadership in 2024, we urged that the generational investment in the new Airo fleet be used to expand onboard bicycle capacity. Then-Chief Executive Stephen Gardner confirmed that each Airo passenger car would include a rack holding two bicycles, and that some Airo trainsets would also offer a baggage compartment suitable for additional bicycle storage. With the *Cascades* line having received its first Airo trainset in May 2026 — expected to enter passenger service this fall¹ — and the rollout continuing across 14 additional routes in the years ahead, we are excited to see bicycle-carrying capacity expand across the network.² The demand is there to meet it: Amtrak set a ridership record in FY2025 with 34.5 million customer trips, and bicycles have been a small but durable part of that story since the carry-on program launched in 2015.³

To help guide the next phase of that work, the League of American Bicyclists has developed a report for the Task Force benchmarking the bike-inclusiveness of the Amtrak network. Adapting criteria from the European Cyclists' Federation's 2021 and 2025 *Cyclists Love Trains* reports for an American rail context, we scored all 46 Amtrak lines on a 0–100 scale. The report — *Bicycle-Friendly Trains* — is forthcoming, and we expect to publish it in the coming weeks. Once it is released, we would be glad to walk any interested members of your team through its findings.

¹ McLoon, A. (2026, May 16). *First Next-Generation Amtrak Cascades Train Arrives in Seattle*. King TV Channel 5 News. <https://www.king5.com/article/news/community/transportation/next-generation-amtrak-cascades-train-seattle/281-65cc1d7f-8851-4e57-8892-7c73ae6f0570>

² Amtrak Airo Fleet. (n.d.). *Amtrak Media*. <https://media.amtrak.com/airo-fleet/>

³ 2025 Pay for Performance Rewards: Improve Performance, Reduce Costs, Retain Talent (pp. 1–14). (2025). Amtrak. <https://www.amtrak.com/content/dam/projects/dotcom/english/public/documents/corporate/FY2025-Performance-Incentive-Program-122625.pdf>

Appendix SS (continued)

Amtrak Bike Task Force's Letter to Amtrak President Roger Harris (July 22, 2026)

The picture it paints is, on balance, an encouraging one — and worth dwelling on for a moment. It is heartening because the top of the American chart looks a little like the European one. The *Cascades* and *Gold Runner* services scored 87 and 86 out of 100 using criteria adapted from the European Cyclists' Federation, just shy of the 88-point marks earned by Belgium's and Switzerland's national railways in the 2025 *Cyclists Love Trains* report. It is promising because the demand has been there all along: by September 2020, more than 232,953 bikes had traveled with their riders on Amtrak since the carry-on program launched in October 2015, generating over \$1 million in revenue in just under five years — a quiet but durable signal that, when the service exists, riders use it.⁴ It is a cause for optimism because Amtrak's Airo rollout — the largest fleet replacement since 1971⁵ — will, line by line, lift services like the *Vermont* out of the "Moderate" tier and into "Good," roughly doubling bike capacity on many routes and finally retiring the front-wheel-removal requirement that has long discouraged riders, especially those with mobility issues or loaded touring bikes. And it is significant because Amtrak met its Task Force partners halfway on the Airo design at precisely the moment when a once-in-a-generation federal investment made that alignment of priorities possible.

That distinction points to the central finding of the report, which deserves to be stated plainly: an Amtrak that is welcoming to bicyclists is not Amtrak's project alone. 97% of Amtrak's route-miles run on tracks the railroad does not own, and only 13% of stations, 9% of platforms, and 7% of parking facilities are under Amtrak's sole control. Along lines like the *Cardinal*, the *Crescent*, and the *Floridian*, whether a cyclist can board, lock up, and reach the trailhead is decided not in Washington but by a city public works department, a state DOT, a regional planning organization, or a chamber of commerce. Our report reflects this by including recommendations not only for Amtrak but for station and platform owners, host communities, local businesses & tourism bureaus, and individual advocates.

Our three case studies bear this out. Anniston, Alabama's platform extension — the project that will finally bring bike service to a station now sitting at the end of a 100-mile paved trail — required a city, a regional rail commission, a metropolitan planning organization, and years of patience. The *Capitol Corridor*'s bikeshare payment-integration pilot in Davis, California, brought together Amtrak, a joint powers authority, a university, a state mobility office, and a private operator. The wayfinding signs that now point cyclists toward the Amtrak station in Columbia, South Carolina, came from a small nonprofit, a city planning department, and a public-health grant. None of these efforts waited for Amtrak to lead — and all of them made Amtrak more useful.

With the Airo investment now largely locked in and no comparable equipment redesign yet at a stage where our input could shape it, the Task Force has shifted its focus accordingly — away from rolling stock and toward the parts of the journey that surround the train: how customers find bike-eligible service, how they book it, where they can board, and how carriage is priced. Our four recommendations for Amtrak, detailed in the *Bicycle-Friendly Trains* report and summarized here, follow from that shift.

⁴ Abrams, J., & Toll, B. (2020, September 3). Amtrak Expands Carry-On Bike Program on Northeast Regional and Northeast State-Supported Trains. *Amtrak Media*.
<https://media.amtrak.com/2020/09/amtrak-expands-carry-on-bike-program-on-northeast-regional-and-northeast-state-supported-trains/>

⁵ Bardolf, D. (2026, February 14). *Amtrak Adding Over 80 New Trains in Massive Overhaul of Fleet; Travelers React*. Fox News.
<https://www.foxnews.com/travel/amtrak-adding-over-80-new-trains-massive-overhaul-fleet-travelers-react-amp>

Appendix SS (continued)

Amtrak Bike Task Force's Letter to Amtrak President Roger Harris (July 22, 2026)

1. Make bike service legible on the website. The 2024 addition of a bike-service filter at the time of booking was a real improvement. The next step is a clear, at-a-glance list of which stations offer bicycle service and whether it is carry-on or checked, so a customer can see a route's bike options before beginning a reservation, rather than discovering them transaction by transaction.

2. Fix reservation-system inconsistencies. In some cases, the system lets a customer reserve a bike space for one direction of a round trip but not the return, or sell a bike ticket to a final station that has no bike service. A published station-by-station service list would resolve much of this. We would also ask Amtrak to notify passengers holding bike reservations when rail-replacement buses — which often cannot carry bicycles — are scheduled, giving riders enough notice to make other arrangements.

3. Expand bike service at high-potential unstaffed stations. We appreciate that Amtrak has extended service to crewless stations in areas of high bike demand — Prince, WV, and West Glacier, MT, among them — and we would welcome the chance to help identify more, particularly where local communities are eager partners. Three stand out:

- **Anniston, AL (ATN)**, on the *Crescent*, now sits at the southern end of the Chief Ladiga Trail, which connects to Georgia's Silver Comet Trail to form roughly 100 continuous miles of paved rail-trail toward Atlanta.⁶ The city government has been seeking to work with Amtrak on bringing bike service to the station.
- **White Sulphur Springs, WV (WSS)**, on the *Cardinal*, is the gateway to the Monongahela National Forest, the 78-mile Greenbrier River Trail, and the new Mon Forest Gravel and Bikepacking Route Network launched in 2026. The nearby unstaffed Prince, WV (PRC) station already demonstrates that bike service at a crewless stop is feasible; we hope the same can be extended to White Sulphur Springs along this eight-stop Mountain State corridor.
- **Greenville, SC (GRV)**, on the *Crescent*, is less than half a mile from the Swamp Rabbit Trail, a regional tourism anchor generating roughly \$6.7 million annually.⁷ Amtrak already promotes Greenville and the Swamp Rabbit Trail on its *Crescent* route page — yet the unstaffed station offers no bike service. Allowing it would simply align the service with Amtrak's own marketing.

4. Simplify bike-fee payment, beginning with a bundled rail pass. We continue to ask that customers be charged for bike carriage only once per itinerary, even when connecting, and we understand the current reservation system makes this difficult. As a first step, we propose a "USA Rail + Bike" pass: a premium tier of the existing USA Rail Pass that bundles bicycle carriage across every leg of a trip rather than charging per segment. The add-on could be priced to recover Amtrak's carriage costs on national, non-state-supported lines, where no state subsidy applies. For Amtrak, it converts a recurring source of customer-service friction into a single revenue-generating product; for cyclists, it offers cost certainty and a strong reason to choose the train for long, multi-leg journeys.

These four changes support a sustainable multimodal network, help solve the first- and last-mile problem for many travelers, and make Amtrak more accessible to cyclists. We also want to acknowledge what may be the next great opportunity: Amtrak's recently announced steps toward replacing its long-distance fleet — the equipment underpinning some of the lowest-scoring lines in our benchmark. Just as the Task Force worked with Amtrak to build bike capacity into the Airo design at the right moment, we would welcome the chance to do the same here, and we stand ready to help.

⁶ City of Anniston. (n.d.). Chief Ladiga Trail. <https://anniston.al.gov/chief-ladiga/>

⁷ *Stronger Economies through Active Communities: The Economic Impact of Walkable, Bikeable Communities in South Carolina* (pp. 1–32). (2016). Eat Smart Move More South Carolina. <https://townofblacksburgsc.com/wp-content/uploads/2020/12/How-Trails-Impact-Economic-Development.pdf>

Appendix SS (continued)

Amtrak Bike Task Force's Letter to Amtrak President Roger Harris (July 22, 2026)

Finally, we want to thank Mariah Morales for her work helping us understand both the challenges and the opportunities in improving bike service across Amtrak. We hope Mariah will continue to provide the Task Force with quarterly updates on bicycle carriage numbers across Amtrak lines. That data — including which station pairs carry the most bikes — is invaluable to keeping our local and state partners informed, so they can anticipate demand and respond. We look forward to your continued partnership and to the road ahead.

Please reach out to the Amtrak Bike Task Force Coordinator, Caron Whitaker, at 202-215-3908 or Caron@bikeleague.org with any questions.

Thank you,



Caron Whitaker

Coordinator, Amtrak Bike Task Force

CC: Mariah Morales, Amtrak

Appendix TT

Amtrak Bike Task Force Member Organizations



**Adventure
Cycling**



**PALMETTO
WALK-BIKE**



Out Our Front Door



Appendix UU

A Note on the *Capitol Corridor*

During final review, a discrepancy in the reported bicycle-carriage capacity of the *Capitol Corridor* was identified. Figures reported by Amtrak differ from those on the *Capitol Corridor*'s own website, which describes two designated self-service “bike cars” on each train, each holding roughly a dozen bicycles plus three lower-level bike racks in every car.¹²⁰ Amtrak was unable to verify these route-specific figures (as of July 21, 2026), and to keep every line scored against a single consistent source, this report uses the capacity figures provided directly by Amtrak.

The *Capitol Corridor* remains classified as carry-on only, since its bike cars are self-service and riders secure their own bicycles. Were the *Corridor*'s figures for bike-spaces used, however, its score in that category would reach the maximum, and it would gain a bonus for exceeding ten spaces, raising the line from 46 (Moderate) to 83 (Excellent)—behind only *Cascades* (87) and *Gold Runner* (86) network-wide. We highlight the *Corridor*'s configuration as a promising model and welcome verified route-level data from Amtrak and the *Capitol Corridor* Joint Powers Authority in future editions.

¹²⁰ *Capitol Corridor*. (n.d.). “Bikes on Board: Taking Your Bike on *Capitol Corridor* Trains.” <https://www.capitolcorridor.org/bicycles/>

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About the League

For generations past and to come, the League represents bicyclists in the movement to create safer roads, stronger communities, and a Bicycle Friendly America. Through education, advocacy, and promotion, we work to celebrate and preserve the freedom cycling brings to our members everywhere.

WE BELIEVE

- Bicycling brings people together.
- When more people ride bikes:
 - Life is better for everyone;
 - Communities are safer, stronger, and better connected;
 - Our nation is healthier, economically stronger, environmentally cleaner, and more energy independent.

OUR VISION

is a nation where everyone recognizes and enjoys the many benefits and opportunities of bicycling.

OUR MISSION

is to lead the movement to create a Bicycle Friendly America for everyone. As leaders, our commitment is to listen and learn, define standards and share best practices to engage diverse communities, and build a powerful, unified voice for change.

